

THE COMPLETE

IELTS MASTERCLASS

A Complete Preparation Course in Listening, Reading,
Writing and Speaking — Academic and General Training

Compiled, expanded and systematised from the complete
12-Hour IELTS Master-Course of the Four Components
(twelve recorded live sessions, transcribed in full)

Band 5 → Band 8+ • Strategy, Language, Practice, Answer Keys

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How This Book Was Made

Provenance, method, and the best way to use the twelve chapters that follow

This book has one unusual property: it was not written from a syllabus. It was written from a **classroom**.

The source material is the complete *12 Hours Full Course for Beginners — Master-Course of the 4 Components*, a live IELTS preparation course delivered over a series of sessions and published as twelve video parts. Every one of those twelve parts was transcribed in full and then studied line by line: the teacher's explanations, the rules he repeats until the class can recite them, the corrections he makes to students' live answers, the exercises he sets, the model sentences he builds on the whiteboard, and — just as valuable — the mistakes the students actually make, which are the same mistakes candidates make in the real exam.

What you are holding is that twelve-hour course reorganised into a reference book, with every rule made explicit, every half-finished example completed, every scattered remark gathered into the chapter where it belongs, and a very large amount of additional scaffolding added: full band descriptor tables, expanded language banks, worked model answers, complete practice sets and answer keys.

What the original course covered

The course is built around the structure the teacher announces in the first session and keeps returning to: the four components, in the order the test itself presents them.

Session block	Component	Principal content
Parts 1–2	Listening	Instruction-reading, word limits, all ten question types, prediction, signposting, distractors, spelling and number traps, full practice sets
Parts 3–4	Reading	Skimming and scanning, topic sentences, True/False/Not Given, matching headings, paraphrase-hunting, summary and diagram completion, timing strategy
Parts 8–9, 11–12	Writing Task 1	Academic data description (line graphs, bar charts, pie charts, tables, processes, maps) and General Training letters; overview rules, word counts, figure use, comparison language
Parts 9–12	Writing Task 2	Essay types, four/five-paragraph architecture, thesis statements, topic sentences, cohesion, sentence variety, concession structures
Parts 5–7	Speaking	The three parts, the four criteria, fluency and fillers, extending answers, the cue card, abstract discussion, pronunciation
Throughout	Language systems	Grammar for range and accuracy, vocabulary upgrading, pronunciation, accent awareness

The teacher's core convictions

Several ideas recur so often in the twelve hours that they function as the spine of the whole course. They are worth stating at the outset, because everything else in this book is an elaboration of them.

The five convictions of the course

- 1. Reading and Listening are won by technique; Writing and Speaking are won by production.** As the teacher puts it, many candidates get good scores in Listening and Reading, "but when it comes to writing and speaking, now we need to stop a little bit — because writing and speaking are the productive skills. You are going to produce language, and as long as you produce language, you are going to be judged."
- 2. Instructions are part of the test.** Word limits ("NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER") are not advice. Breaking them scores zero even when the content is right.
- 3. The examiner marks a rubric, not an impression.** Four named criteria, each worth 25%. You can reverse-engineer every one of them.
- 4. Paraphrase is the central skill of the entire exam.** Listening answers are paraphrased in the recording; reading answers are paraphrased in the passage; writing introductions must paraphrase the prompt; speaking answers must not echo the question.
- 5. Never give a short answer, and never over-write.** In Speaking, a one-clause reply is a wasted question. In Writing, 300 words is not a sign of cleverness; it is a sign of poor control.

How to use this book

Read Chapter 1 once, for the architecture of the test. After that, the book is designed to be used in three different ways.

As a course. Work through Chapters 2–8 in order over eight to ten weeks, one component at a time, doing every exercise. Chapter 12 gives you three dated study plans (four weeks, eight weeks, twelve weeks) built exactly on that sequence.

As a clinic. If one skill is holding your overall band down, go straight to its chapter. Each component chapter is self-contained and ends with a diagnostic checklist and a set of practice tasks with keys.

As a reference. Chapters 9 (Grammar), 10 (Vocabulary and Paraphrase) and 11 (Pronunciation) are language banks. Keep returning to them while you write and speak. The appendices in Chapter 13 collect every list in the book — linking words, trend verbs, functional language, letter phrases, cue-card frameworks — in one place for revision in the final week.

Conventions used throughout

- Text in quotation marks with an indent is **the teacher's own phrasing** from the recorded sessions, lightly cleaned of false starts.
- Boxes with a blue bar are **key rules** — the non-negotiables.
- Boxes with a red bar are **warnings** — the band-destroying mistakes.
- Boxes with a green bar are **band-raisers** — the things that separate 6.5 from 7.5.
- Model answers are written at the band level stated above them. Where two versions appear, compare them sentence by sentence; the gap between them is the lesson.

A word about honesty in preparation

The single most common reason a well-prepared candidate underperforms is that they practised under conditions kinder than the exam. Untimed reading, a second listen to the recording, a dictionary open while writing, a rehearsed speech for the cue card. Every practice task in this book states its time limit. Keep it. A Band 7 essay written in fifty minutes is a Band 6 essay in the exam.

Chapter 1 — The Test, The Scoring, and the Strategy Behind Both

What you are actually being measured on, and how the numbers work

Before any technique is useful, you need an accurate mental model of the machine you are feeding. Most candidates carry a vague one, and the vagueness costs them half a band. This chapter builds a precise one.

1.1 The two versions of IELTS

IELTS comes in two forms. **Academic** is for university entry and professional registration. **General Training** is for migration, secondary education and work experience. They are not two different tests; they are one test with two of its four components partially swapped.

Component	Academic	General Training	Time
Listening	Identical	Identical	30 min + 10 min transfer (paper)
Reading	3 long academic passages, 40 questions	5 shorter texts: social survival, workplace, one long general-interest passage, 40 questions	60 min, no extra transfer time
Writing Task 1	Describe visual data: graph, chart, table, process, map	Write a letter: formal, semi-formal or informal	20 min recommended
Writing Task 2	Discursive essay	Discursive essay (slightly simpler topics)	40 min recommended
Speaking	Identical	Identical	11–14 min

Two consequences follow immediately, and the course stresses both.

First, **Listening and Speaking are shared**, so roughly half of everything in this book applies to every candidate regardless of version. Second, **General Training Reading is not "easier" — it is differently hard**. The texts are simpler, but the pass mark is higher. The same raw score buys you a lower band.

1.2 The band scale, and what the raw scores buy

Each of the four components is scored from 0 to 9 in half bands. The **Overall Band Score** is the mean of the four, rounded to the nearest half band, with .25 rounding up and .75 rounding up.

Rounding, concretely

$6.0 + 6.0 + 6.5 + 6.5 = 25.0 \div 4 = 6.25 \rightarrow$ rounds up to 6.5

$6.0 + 6.0 + 6.0 + 6.5 = 24.5 \div 4 = 6.125 \rightarrow$ rounds down to 6.0

$6.5 + 6.5 + 6.0 + 7.0 = 26.0 \div 4 = 6.5$ exactly

This is why half a band in your weakest component is often worth more than a full band in your strongest.

Listening: raw score to band (both versions)

Raw score /40	Band	Raw score /40	Band
39–40	9.0	23–25	6.0

Raw score /40	Band	Raw score /40	Band
37–38	8.5	20–22	5.5
35–36	8.0	16–19	5.0
32–34	7.5	13–15	4.5
30–31	7.0	11–12	4.0
26–29	6.5	8–10	3.5

Reading: raw score to band

Raw /40	Academic	General Training
39–40	9.0	9.0
37–38	8.5	8.5 (40 for 9.0)
35–36	8.0	8.0 needs 37–38
33–34	7.5	7.5 needs 36
30–32	7.0	7.0 needs 34–35
27–29	6.5	6.5 needs 32–33
23–26	6.0	6.0 needs 30–31
19–22	5.5	5.5 needs 27–29
15–18	5.0	5.0 needs 23–26

Read those two columns side by side. For Band 7, Academic needs 30 correct; General Training needs 34. The gap is real and it catches GT candidates who assume the simpler texts mean an easier ride.

Writing and Speaking: criterion-based

There is no raw score. Four named criteria, each contributing **25%** of the component band, are scored 0–9 and averaged.

	Writing Task 1 & 2	Speaking
Criterion 1	Task Achievement (T1) / Task Response (T2)	Fluency and Coherence
Criterion 2	Coherence and Cohesion	Lexical Resource
Criterion 3	Lexical Resource	Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Criterion 4	Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Pronunciation

And one detail that changes how you spend your fifty minutes of writing:

Task 2 is worth twice Task 1

The Writing band is calculated as $(\text{Task 1} \times 1 + \text{Task 2} \times 2) \div 3$. As the teacher says repeatedly, Task 1 is "one third of the whole mark." A brilliant Task 1 cannot rescue a thin Task 2. Write Task 1 in twenty minutes and get out.

Worked example: Task 1 scores 6.0, Task 2 scores 7.0. Writing band = $(6 + 14) \div 3 = 6.67 \rightarrow \mathbf{6.5}$. Reverse it — Task 1 at 7.0, Task 2 at 6.0 — and you get $(7 + 12) \div 3 = 6.33 \rightarrow \mathbf{6.5}$ as well, but you were one mark from 6.0. The asymmetry always favours protecting Task 2.

1.3 The shape of the test day

Listening, Reading and Writing are taken back to back with no breaks, in that order, totalling two hours and forty minutes. Speaking may be on the same day or up to seven days before or after.

The transfer-time trap

In the **paper-based** test you get ten extra minutes after Listening to copy answers onto the answer sheet. In **Reading you do not**. Your answers must be on the answer sheet within the sixty minutes. In the **computer-based** test there is no transfer time for Listening either — you type directly, with two minutes at the end to check. Know which test you are taking, and practise in that format.

1.4 Where the marks actually leak

Across twelve hours of live teaching and student correction, the same failure modes appear again and again. They are worth naming now, because each chapter of this book is in some sense a response to one of them.

Leak	Component	Chapter
Exceeding the word limit	Listening, Reading	2, 3
Writing the right idea but misspelling it	Listening	2
Answering from knowledge instead of the text	Reading (T/F/NG)	3
Reading every word instead of scanning	Reading	3
No overview paragraph	Writing Task 1	4
Describing every data point instead of selecting	Writing Task 1	4
No clear position; essay drifts	Writing Task 2	6
One-sentence, unsupported answers	Speaking	7
Memorised speeches that don't answer the question	Speaking	7
Simple sentences only, no subordination	Writing, Speaking	9
Repeating the prompt's vocabulary verbatim	Writing, Speaking	10
Mispronunciation causing genuine misunderstanding	Speaking	11

1.5 A diagnostic to run before you read on

Do this honestly, this week, before you study anything. You need a baseline.

- 1 Take one **full Listening test** under exam conditions, one play only. Mark it. Record the raw score and, crucially, categorise every error: *didn't hear it*, *heard it but spelled it wrong*, *broke the word limit*, *lost my place*.

- 2 Take one **full Reading test** in sixty minutes with no extensions. Mark it. Note how many questions you left blank because you ran out of time.
- 3 Write **one Task 2 essay in forty minutes**, handwritten if you are taking the paper test. Count the words. Count the paragraphs.
- 4 Record yourself answering **eight Part 1 Speaking questions** and one cue card. Listen back with a stopwatch: how long is your average Part 1 answer? If it is under fifteen seconds, that alone is costing you a band.

Write the four results on the inside cover of this book. In eight weeks, repeat the diagnostic. The comparison is the only honest feedback you have.

The strategic conclusion of this chapter

Your overall band is the *mean* of four numbers. The fastest route upward is almost never "improve my English." It is: find the lowest of the four numbers, identify which specific leak in the table above is producing it, and close that leak. Most candidates can gain a full band in eight weeks without their underlying English improving at all — purely by no longer throwing marks away.

Chapter 2 — Listening

Thirty minutes, forty questions, one play: the component where technique beats fluency

Listening is the component where a candidate with modest English can outperform a fluent speaker who has not learned the system. The recording plays **once**. There is no rewind. Everything therefore depends on being in the right place, at the right moment, expecting the right kind of word.

The course devotes its first two sessions almost entirely to this component, and the emphasis is unmistakable: *instructions first, prediction second, everything else third*.

2.1 The architecture of the test

Section	Context	Speakers	Typical difficulty
Part 1	Everyday social transaction: booking, enquiry, registration	2 speakers	Easiest. Names, numbers, dates, addresses
Part 2	Monologue on a social topic: a tour, a facility, an announcement	1 speaker	Maps, plans, matching
Part 3	Educational/training discussion: a tutorial, a project meeting	2–4 speakers	Hardest. Opinions, disagreement, multiple choice
Part 4	Academic lecture on any subject	1 speaker	Dense. Note/summary completion, no break mid-part

Ten questions per part. The recording moves strictly forward through the questions — question 7 is always answered after question 6. If you miss one, you have lost one mark, not the section. **Let it go immediately**. The single most expensive habit in Listening is continuing to hunt for question 6 while questions 7, 8 and 9 go past.

The cascade failure

Missing one answer is worth one mark. Missing one answer and then losing your place is worth five. The instant you realise you have missed something, move your pencil to the next question and look at it. Recovery beats retrieval, every time.

2.2 Instructions are part of the test

The course opens its listening practice not with a recording but with a line of text, and spends several minutes on it:

“The instructions are saying what? “NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER.” So in this case your answer may take several forms.”

That phrase — *and/or* — is doing real work. Unpack the possibilities:

Instruction	Permitted answers
ONE WORD ONLY	station
ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER	station, 14, platform 14
NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS	bus station, station
NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER	bus station, 14 Mill Road, station 14, 14

Instruction	Permitted answers
NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER	the old bus station, 3 September 1994

Three rules govern the counting, and they decide marks:

- Hyphenated compounds count as one word.** part-time is one word. air-conditioning is one word.
- Numbers written as digits count as a number, not a word.** 25 is a number; twenty-five is one word. Write digits — they are faster and safer.
- Articles count.** the bus station is three words. If the limit is two, write bus station. Grammatical articles are almost never required for the answer to be correct.

Over the limit scores zero, even when the meaning is perfect.

Limit: TWO WORDS. Recording: "...you'll need to bring a valid student identity card."

Correct: student card or identity card.

Marked wrong: a student identity card (four words), student identity card (three words).

The candidate understood everything and scored nothing. This is the cheapest mark in IELTS to lose and the easiest to protect: before you write, count.

2.3 The prediction routine — what to do in the silences

You are given short pauses before each section to read the questions. This time is not a courtesy; it is the most valuable thirty seconds in the test. Use it for a fixed four-step routine.

The four-step pre-listening routine

- Read the instruction and circle the word limit.** Write "2W" or "3W+N" at the top of the section.
- Underline the keywords** in each question — the content words that carry the meaning.
- Predict the grammar of the gap.** Is a noun needed? Singular or plural? A number? A date? A name? A verb? Write a tiny note: n . p l, £, day, time.
- Predict the paraphrase.** The recording will not use the words on your question paper. If the question says "the cost of membership", expect to hear *how much it is to join, the fee, you'd pay*.

Step 3 is the one most candidates skip, and it is the one that catches errors. Consider:

"Students must bring their own _____ to the first session."

The gap is after a possessive determiner and before a prepositional phrase. It must be a **noun**, and because "their own" suggests one item each, it is plausibly **singular or plural** — so listen for the -s. If you hear "you'll want to bring notebooks", the answer is notebooks. If you write notebook, you lose the mark. The grammar of the sentence is a free hint that arrives before the audio does.

Predicting from the number type

Gap context	Listen for
"costs £ ____"	A price; watch for corrections: "it's £40 — sorry, £45 for non-members"
"on ____"	A day or date: "the fourteenth of March" → 14 March
"at ____"	A time: "half past nine" → 9.30
"call ____"	A phone number, read in groups; "double four" = 44; "oh" = 0
"number ____"	Room, platform, house number

Gap context	Listen for
"____ per cent"	A percentage

2.4 Signposting: how speakers tell you the answer is coming

Native speakers mark important information with predictable verbal packaging. Learning to hear the packaging is learning to hear the answer arriving.

Function	Signals
Emphasis / importance	<i>the key thing is, what really matters, above all, don't forget, make sure you</i>
Listing / sequence	<i>firstly, then, after that, finally, another thing</i>
Contrast / change of direction	<i>however, although, on the other hand, having said that, mind you</i>
Correction (the distractor trap)	<i>actually, sorry, no wait, I mean, let me rephrase, in fact</i>
Exemplification	<i>for instance, such as, like, namely</i>
Conclusion / summary	<i>so overall, to sum up, the point is</i>

The correction signals deserve their own section, because they are how the test separates Band 6 from Band 8.

2.5 Distractors — the single biggest source of lost marks

A distractor is a plausible wrong answer that is spoken *before* the right one. The test designers know that candidates write the first thing that fits and stop listening.

The three distractor patterns

1. Self-correction. "The meeting's on Tuesday — sorry, no, Wednesday, they moved it."

Answer: **Wednesday**.

2. Rejected option. "We could use the main hall, but it's being redecorated, so we'll be in the Library Room."

Answer: **Library Room**.

3. Negation. "You don't need to bring a laptop; the tablets are provided."

Answer: **tablets** (and NOT laptop).

In every case, the wrong answer is spoken first, clearly, and matches the question's keywords. Never write and relax. Keep listening until the speaker has moved on to the next topic.

A practical technique: **write in pencil, lightly, and be ready to cross out**. Candidates who commit in ink, psychologically, stop listening. Treat your first answer as a hypothesis that the next eight seconds may overturn.

2.6 The ten question types

Type 1 — Form / Note / Table / Flow-chart completion

The most common Part 1 and Part 4 type. You are completing a structured document.

Strategy. The layout tells you the answer type. In a form, "Surname: ____" means a name that will be spelled out. "Address: ____" means a street, and numbers come first. In a flow-chart, arrows mean stages of a process, so answers are often verbs or noun phrases in a sequence.

Spelling is marked. A correctly heard answer spelled wrongly scores zero. Names and places are almost always spelled out letter by letter in the recording precisely so that spelling can be tested. Write the letters as you hear them, then check.**

The confusable letter pairs in spoken English: B/P/V, D/T, M/N, S/F, G/J, I/E, A/E/8. When a speaker spells, they often clarify: "S for sugar", "double L", "that's with a K not a C".

Practice 2.1 — Form completion. Write **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER**.

“LIBRARY MEMBERSHIP FORM Name: Katherine (1) _____ Address: (2) _____
Road, Millbrook Occupation: (3) _____ Membership type: (4) _____ Annual fee: £ (5) _____
Card ready on: (6) _____”

Transcript extract: "Right, can I take your name? — Katherine Villiers. That's V-I-double L-I-E-R-S. — Lovely. And the address? — It's 37 Bracken Road, that's B-R-A-C-K-E-N, in Millbrook. — Thank you. And your occupation? — I'm a radiographer at the hospital. — Now, we do three types: standard, concession and family. Students and over-65s get the concession rate. — I'd like the family one, my two children read constantly. — Family it is. That's normally £48 a year, but there's an offer on at the moment so it's £36. — And when can I collect the card? — Normally five working days, but as you've applied in person it'll be ready on Thursday."

Key: (1) Villiers (2) 37 Bracken (3) radiographer (4) family (5) 36 — *not 48; the offer overrides* (6) Thursday — *not "five working days"*.

Notice questions 5 and 6: both are distractor traps of the "rejected option" kind. The wrong number and the wrong timeframe were both spoken first.

Type 2 — Sentence completion

You complete a sentence with words **from the recording**, within the word limit.

Strategy. Read the whole sentence, not just the words next to the gap. The sentence is a paraphrase of what will be said; the gap is the one part that isn't paraphrased. Check that your answer makes the sentence grammatically correct — if it doesn't, it is wrong.

Type 3 — Short-answer questions

"Answer the questions below. Write **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS**."

Strategy. The question word tells you the answer type: *What* → thing; *Where* → place; *When* → time; *Who* → person; *How many* → number; *Why* → reason (listen for *because, since, so that, the reason is*).

Watch for **plural traps**: "What **TWO** things must students bring?" requires two items, and both must be right for the mark.

Type 4 — Multiple choice

Three options (A/B/C), occasionally longer lists where you choose two or three from five.

Strategy. This type punishes keyword-matching more than any other. All three options are usually *mentioned* in the recording; only one is *true in the way the question asks*.

How the three options are designed

The right answer is paraphrased — it never uses the recording's exact words.

Distractor 1 uses the recording's exact words but reverses, exaggerates or mistimes the meaning.

Distractor 2 is true but answers a different question, or is true of a different speaker.

So: the option that sounds most familiar is the one most likely to be wrong.

Example.

“Q: The speaker says the new timetable is A) more popular with students than the old one B) difficult for part-time staff C) going to be reviewed next term”

Recording: "Students seem to like it — certainly we've had fewer complaints. The real issue has been our part-time colleagues, who've found the early starts almost impossible to accommodate. We'll live with it for now and see."

A is *nearly* true ("seem to like it", "fewer complaints") but is not what "the speaker says" most strongly; C is vague ("see" is not "review next term"); **B** is the answer, paraphrased from "almost impossible to accommodate".

Where the question says **"Choose TWO letters"**, the two correct options are usually separated in the recording by a stretch of irrelevant speech. Do not expect them consecutively.

Type 5 — Matching

You match a list of items (people, places, years) to a set of options (A–F).

Strategy. The options are static; the items arrive in recording order. So track the *items*, not the options. Write the option letter next to the item as it is mentioned. Where options can be used more than once, the instruction says so explicitly — read it.

A very common Part 3 variant matches **opinions to speakers**: "Who thinks X — the tutor, James or Sarah?" Here the key skill is voice discrimination and attribution. Listen for *I think, in my view, I'd say*, and the agreement/disagreement markers: *absolutely, I'm not so sure, that's true, but, exactly*.

Type 6 — Plan, map and diagram labelling

The type students fear most, and the course drills it heavily. You label locations on a map or parts of a diagram.

The map routine

- 1. Find yourself.** Locate the entrance, the "you are here" marker, or the starting point named in the recording. Put your pencil on it.
- 2. Establish orientation.** Note which way is north; identify the main axis (a road, a corridor, a river).
- 3. Read the labels already given.** These are the landmarks the speaker will navigate by.
- 4. Move your pencil.** As the speaker describes the route, physically trace it. Do not try to hold the route in your head.

The language of spatial description — memorise this.

Direction	Position	Sequence
go straight ahead / carry on	opposite / facing	first you come to
turn left / right	next to / beside / adjacent to	then / after that
take the first turning on your left	between X and Y	just before you reach
head north / south	in the corner of	immediately after
go past / go through	at the far end	at the very back
cross over	on your left-hand side	if you keep going
bear left (a gentle turn)	behind / in front of	you'll eventually come to

Direction	Position	Sequence
go up / down (stairs, a slope)	halfway along	as soon as you enter
all the way round	in the middle of	finally

Practice 2.2 — Map labelling. A visitor centre. Entrance at the bottom (south). A central corridor runs north. Rooms A–H line both sides.

Transcript extract: "So you come in through the main doors here at the south end. Immediately on your left as you enter is the cloakroom — do leave your bags there. Directly opposite it, on your right, is the ticket desk. Now walk straight up the corridor. About halfway along on the right-hand side you'll find the cafe, which is open until four. Just past the cafe, still on the right, is the gift shop. On the left-hand side, opposite the gift shop, we have the main exhibition hall. And right at the far end of the corridor, straight ahead of you, is the lecture theatre."

If the map's rooms are lettered clockwise from the entrance, you can now place: cloakroom, ticket desk, cafe, gift shop, exhibition hall, lecture theatre — six answers from one paragraph, entirely through spatial prepositions. Note how often "opposite" and "just past" carry the entire mark.

Type 7 — Summary completion

A paragraph-length summary of part of the recording, with gaps. Sometimes with a word box, sometimes without.

Strategy. If there is a **word box**, the words in it will *not* be the words in the recording — they are synonyms. Do the vocabulary work first: group the box words by part of speech, then by meaning. If there is **no box**, the words come from the recording verbatim and the word limit applies.

Type 8 — Table completion

Common in Part 4. Rows and columns give you the structure of the lecture.

Strategy. The column headings tell you the answer category. Read across *and* down — if three cells in a column contain dates, the fourth is a date.

Type 9 — Flow-chart completion

A process with stages linked by arrows.

Strategy. The answer is usually a noun or a verb in a fixed grammatical slot. Listen for sequencers: *first, next, once that's done, the following stage, finally*.

Type 10 — Classification

Items are assigned to categories (e.g. "Which period does each building belong to: A 1800s, B 1900s, C 2000s?").

Strategy. Only two or three categories, many items. The categories repeat, so the recording will cycle through them. Track items in order and write letters.

2.7 Numbers, letters, dates: the mechanical marks

These questions are free marks that candidates throw away through unfamiliarity with spoken conventions.

Spoken	Write
"double four"	44
"treble eight" / "triple eight"	888

Spoken	Write
"oh seven nine" (phone)	079
"nineteen ninety-four"	1994
"two thousand and nine"	2009
"twenty twenty-three"	2023
"the third of June" / "June the third"	3 June (or 3rd June)
"a quarter past eight"	8.15
"twenty to seven"	6.40
"half past nine"	9.30
"half nine" (informal British)	9.30
"fifteen hundred hours"	15.00 / 3 pm
"a hundred and twenty thousand"	120,000
"one point five million"	1.5 million / 1,500,000
"thirty pounds fifty"	£30.50
"forty per cent"	40%

Thirteen or thirty?

The distinction is **stress**, not vowel. *THIR-teen* has a strong first syllable and a clearly pronounced final /n/. *THIR-ty* ends in a flapped or unreleased /t/ and a short /i/. In connected speech, listen for the following word: "thirteen POUNDS" keeps stress on *-teen* when final. If genuinely unsure, use context — a course fee is more likely £30 than £13; a class size is more likely 13 than 30.

2.8 British and American spelling

Both are accepted. But be consistent, and know the pairs, because the recording may be in either accent.

British	American
centre, theatre, metre	center, theater, meter
colour, labour, favour	color, labor, favor
organise, realise, analyse	organize, realize, analyze
travelling, cancelled	traveling, canceled
programme (TV)	program
cheque	check
enrolment	enrollment
licence (n) / license (v)	license (both)

2.9 Part-specific tactics

Part 1 — bank the marks

Part 1 is the only section where near-perfection is realistic. It is a transaction, so the information is concrete: names, numbers, addresses, times, prices. Target 10/10. Every mark dropped here must be clawed back in Part 4, where it is four times harder.

Part 2 — the map or the matching

Expect a monologue with a clear spatial or organisational structure. The speaker is usually giving a tour or introducing a facility. Follow the *physical* or *chronological* order.

Part 3 — the opinion minefield

Two to four speakers, often a tutor and two students, discussing a project. The difficulty is attribution and the density of hedged opinion. Key phrases to track:

Agreeing	Disagreeing	Partially agreeing	Hedging
absolutely	I'm not convinced	up to a point	it tends to
that's exactly it	not necessarily	I see what you mean, but	it seems that
precisely	I'd question that	that's fair, although	arguably
couldn't agree more	on the contrary	yes and no	more or less
good point	that's not quite right	broadly, yes	to some extent

Part 4 — the academic lecture

Ten questions, one speaker, no break in the middle. The single biggest risk is drifting.

Tactics. Read all ten questions in the preparation time (you get one longer pause for the whole part). Because it is a structured lecture, the speaker will signpost: "I want to look at three factors... the first of these is... turning now to... but perhaps the most significant..." Use those signposts as position markers. If you lose the thread, jump forward two questions and wait for the signpost that matches.

2.10 Transfer, checking and the ten minutes

Paper-based: ten minutes at the end. Use them like this — five minutes transferring carefully, three minutes checking spelling and plurals, two minutes filling every blank with a guess. **Never leave a blank.** There is no negative marking.

Computer-based: no transfer time, two minutes to review. Type your answers directly and use the review flag.

The four-point final check

1. **Word limit** — count the words in every completion answer.
2. **Plurals** — does the sentence need -s? Did you hear -s?
3. **Spelling** — especially of any word that was spelled out.
4. **Blanks** — none left. Guess something plausible and of the right word class.

2.11 A four-week Listening training programme

Week 1 — Accuracy. Two sections a day. Do not aim for speed; aim for zero avoidable errors. After every test, categorise your mistakes using the four labels from Chapter 1.5.

Week 2 — Prediction. Before each section, spend a full minute writing your predictions for every gap: word class, number/name/noun, likely paraphrase. Then listen. Score your predictions as well as your answers.

Week 3 — Dictation. Take a two-minute stretch of Part 3 or Part 4 audio and transcribe it completely, word for word, replaying as needed. This is slow and unpleasant and it is the single most effective listening exercise in existence. It forces you to hear the function words, the contractions and the weak forms that carry grammar.

Week 4 — Full tests under pressure. One complete test a day, timed, no pauses, plus the transfer. Review only your errors.

Passive listening that actually helps

Background English does very little on its own. Make it active:

- **Podcasts with transcripts.** Listen once without, once with, once without again.
- **Lectures on unfamiliar subjects.** Part 4 topics are deliberately foreign to you. Practise following structure when you don't know the content.
- **Multiple accents.** IELTS uses British, Australian, New Zealand, Canadian and American speakers. If you only train on American English, the Australian Part 2 will hurt.

2.12 Listening diagnostic checklist

Tick honestly after every practice test.

- I read the word limit and wrote it at the top of each section.
- I underlined keywords in every question before the audio began.
- I predicted the word class of every gap.
- When I missed an answer, I moved on within two seconds.
- I did not write my first plausible answer and stop listening.
- I checked every completion answer against the word limit.
- I left no blanks.
- I spelled every proper noun exactly as it was spelled out.
- I wrote numbers as digits.
- I checked every plural.

Chapter 3 — Reading

Sixty minutes, forty questions, three passages: a test of location, not comprehension

The most damaging belief a candidate can hold about IELTS Reading is that it tests reading. It does not, or not in the ordinary sense. It tests your ability to **locate** specific information in a long text at speed and to **recognise it when it has been reworded**. Deep understanding of the passage is neither required nor rewarded; on the contrary, the candidate who reads for understanding runs out of time.

The course makes this point with unusual force, and returns to two words constantly: **skimming** and **scanning**.

3.1 The arithmetic of sixty minutes

Forty questions. Sixty minutes. **Twenty minutes per passage**, including transferring answers to the answer sheet — because unlike Listening, Reading gives you **no extra transfer time**.

Minute	Activity
0:00–0:02	Skim passage 1 (title, first and last paragraph, first sentence of each paragraph)
0:02–0:04	Read all questions for passage 1, underline keywords
0:04–0:18	Answer, transferring as you go
0:18–0:20	Guess any remaining blanks; move on regardless
0:20–0:40	Passage 2, same pattern
0:40–1:00	Passage 3, same pattern

Passage 3 is the hardest. Some candidates gain by doing it *second*, while they are fresh but warmed up. Experiment in practice; commit before the exam.

The twenty-minute rule is absolute.

At minute twenty you move to passage 2 whether or not passage 1 is finished. Candidates who overrun on passage 1 routinely leave eight to ten questions unattempted on passage 3. Ten blank answers is a two-band penalty. Two wrong answers on passage 1 is a quarter-band penalty. The arithmetic is not close.

3.2 Skimming and scanning: two different skills

These words are used loosely in everyday speech. In IELTS they are precise, distinct operations, and you need both.

Skimming = reading fast for *gist and structure*. You want to know what each paragraph is about, not what it says. Read the title, any subheadings, the first paragraph, the last paragraph, and the first sentence of every paragraph**. Two minutes maximum. Output: a one-word note in the margin beside each paragraph — "history", "criticism", "costs", "example".

Scanning = searching fast for a *specific item*. Your eyes move like a search function, not like a reader. You are hunting a name, a date, a number, a capital letter, an unusual word. You do not read the surrounding sentences until you have a hit.

Why topic sentences matter so much

The course spends considerable time on the **topic sentence** — the sentence, usually first in the paragraph, that states its main idea. English academic prose is overwhelmingly built this way, and that convention is what makes twenty-minute passages possible.

Skim the first sentence of each of eight paragraphs and you have, in roughly ninety seconds, a map of the whole passage. When a question then asks about "the economic objections", you know instantly that it is paragraph E, and you scan only there.

Exercise 3.1. Take any IELTS passage. Cover everything except the first sentence of each paragraph. Write a two-word summary of each. Then uncover and check. If your summaries are accurate for six of eight paragraphs, your skimming is exam-ready.

Where topic sentences hide

Occasionally the main idea is not in sentence one. Two patterns to watch:

The delayed topic sentence — paragraph opens with an anecdote or example, then states the point in sentence two or three. Signalled by: *Consider the case of...*, *In 1897, a young engineer...*

The final topic sentence — paragraph builds evidence and concludes with the point. Signalled by: *Thus, The implication is, What this suggests is.*

If sentence one is a narrative or a statistic, read sentence two and the last sentence before moving on.

3.3 Paraphrase: the mechanism of the whole component

Every question in IELTS Reading is a paraphrase of something in the passage. If the question used the passage's words, the test would be a word-search. Learning to see through paraphrase is therefore the core reading skill.

Paraphrase operates through five mechanisms. Learn to recognise all five.

Mechanism	Passage	Question
Synonym	"the scheme was <i>abandoned</i> "	"the project was <i>discontinued</i> "
Word-class change	"they <i>decided</i> quickly"	"the speed of their <i>decision</i> "
Voice change	"researchers <i>conducted</i> the study"	"the study was <i>carried out</i> by researchers"
Negation of the opposite	"few scientists accepted it"	"it was <i>not widely</i> accepted"
Superordinate	"oaks, beeches and elms"	" <i>deciduous trees</i> "

The fourth is the most dangerous in True/False/Not Given questions, because "*few accepted*" and "*not widely accepted*" look superficially different and mean exactly the same thing.

Building paraphrase reflexes

Exercise 3.2 — Reverse paraphrasing. Take ten sentences from a passage. Rewrite each using no content word from the original. This is hard and slow, and it is the fastest way to build the recognition reflex. Example:

"Original: "Urban populations expanded rapidly during the nineteenth century, placing unprecedented strain on sanitation systems." **Rewritten:** "The number of people living in cities grew very quickly in the 1800s, which put more pressure than ever before on arrangements for public hygiene."

Do ten a day for three weeks. Your Reading band will move.

3.4 True / False / Not Given — and Yes / No / Not Given

The most feared question type, and the most misunderstood. The course drills it more than any other.

The exact meanings

TRUE — the statement agrees with the information in the passage. The passage says this, in different words.

FALSE — the statement contradicts the passage. The passage says the opposite.

NOT GIVEN — the passage neither confirms nor contradicts. The information is simply absent, or is partially there but the specific claim is not made.

YES/NO/NOT GIVEN is identical in mechanism but applies to the *writer's views and claims* rather than factual information. Same logic, different wording.

The two fatal errors

1. Answering from world knowledge. The question asks what *this passage* says. Not what is true. Not what you know. If the passage claims the moon is made of cheese, a statement that the moon is made of cheese is TRUE.

2. Confusing FALSE with NOT GIVEN. FALSE requires a *contradiction you can point to*. If you cannot underline the words that contradict the statement, it is NOT GIVEN. "The passage doesn't mention it" is the definition of NOT GIVEN, not of FALSE.

The decision procedure

- Find the location. Statements come in **passage order** — statement 5 is after statement 4 in the text. Use this ruthlessly.
- Read the relevant sentence and the one on each side.
- Ask: *can I point to words that say this?* → TRUE.
- If not: *can I point to words that say the opposite?* → FALSE.
- If neither: → NOT GIVEN. Do not agonise. Move on.

Worked examples

“Passage: *“The Grand Tunnel was completed in 1843 after eighteen years of construction. Although originally intended for horse-drawn carriages, the access ramps were never built, and it was used solely by pedestrians until 1869, when it was incorporated into the London Underground railway system. It remains in use today.”*”

Statement	Answer	Why
The tunnel took less than twenty years to build.	TRUE	"eighteen years" — a paraphrase by numerical inference
Horse-drawn carriages used the tunnel before 1869.	FALSE	Contradicted: ramps "never built", used "solely by pedestrians"
The tunnel was the first of its kind in the world.	NOT GIVEN	Nothing about precedence anywhere
The tunnel is still part of the Underground network.	TRUE	"remains in use today" following incorporation
Construction of the tunnel was more expensive than planned.	NOT GIVEN	Cost is never mentioned

Look at statement 2. A candidate who reads "originally intended for horse-drawn carriages" and stops will answer TRUE. The word **although** is the whole question. Concessive conjunctions — *although, while, despite, even though* — are where T/F/NG questions live.

Quantifier and modality traps

Small words change truth values completely.

Passage says	Statement says	Verdict
"some researchers argue"	"all researchers argue"	FALSE
"may contribute to"	"causes"	FALSE (certainty added)
"the largest in Europe"	"the largest in the world"	NOT GIVEN or FALSE — check scope
"rarely occurs"	"never occurs"	FALSE
"was one factor"	"was the main factor"	NOT GIVEN
"is likely to"	"will"	FALSE

Always circle: *all, some, most, every, never, always, only, mainly, may, might, must, will, can*. These are where the answer is decided.

Practice 3.1 — T/F/NG.

"Bioluminescence — the production of light by living organisms — occurs in a remarkable range of species, from fireflies to fungi, but it is in the deep ocean that it is most prevalent. Some estimates suggest that more than three-quarters of deep-sea animals are capable of producing light. The functions are varied: attracting prey, deterring predators, and signalling to mates. Dr Helena Marsh, whose team has catalogued over 400 luminescent species, cautions that the underlying chemistry is far from uniform; luciferin, the light-emitting compound, has evolved independently at least forty times."

- 1 Bioluminescence is found in more species on land than in the sea.
- 2 Most deep-sea animals can produce light.
- 3 Dr Marsh's team discovered 400 new species.
- 4 The chemistry of bioluminescence is the same across all species.
- 5 Bioluminescence helps some animals find food.

Key: 1 **FALSE** (deep ocean "most prevalent"). 2 **TRUE** ("more than three-quarters"). 3 **NOT GIVEN** — they *catalogued* 400; nothing says they *discovered* them. 4 **FALSE** ("far from uniform"). 5 **TRUE** ("attracting prey").

Question 3 is the classic NG: a number that matches, a verb that doesn't.

3.5 Matching Headings

You are given a list of headings (i, ii, iii...) and must assign one to each paragraph. There are always more headings than paragraphs.

The method

1. **Do this type last** among the question sets for that passage. By then you will have read most of the paragraphs for other questions.
2. Read all headings first. **Group them** — often two or three headings are near-synonyms, designed so that only one fits precisely.
3. Work paragraph by paragraph, not heading by heading.
4. For each paragraph, read the **first and last sentences** plus any sentence beginning with a contrast marker, then summarise the paragraph in your own words *before* looking at the headings.
5. Cross off each heading as you use it.
6. Do the paragraphs you are certain about first; the leftovers narrow the field for the difficult ones.

A heading describes the paragraph's MAIN idea, not a detail it mentions.

If a paragraph is about the decline of coastal fishing and mentions a 1978 government report in passing, the heading "The impact of government reports" is a trap. Ask: *if this paragraph were deleted, what would the passage lose?* That is the main idea.

3.6 Matching Information to Paragraphs

"Which paragraph contains the following information?" Note the instruction: **any paragraph may be used more than once, or not at all.**

This is the most time-expensive type because the answers are **not in order**. Strategy: do it last, and use your skim-notes. Because you have already noted what each paragraph is about, you can go straight to two or three candidate paragraphs rather than rereading all nine.

3.7 Matching Features / Names

Match statements to researchers, theories, countries or periods. The names in the passage are **capitalised**, which makes them ideal scanning targets — your eye finds capital letters faster than any other feature.

Strategy: scan for each name, mark every occurrence with a letter in the margin, then read only those sentences.

Watch for: one researcher's view being *reported* by another; and names mentioned only to be dismissed.

3.8 Sentence, Summary, Note, Table and Flow-chart Completion

All the completion types share one rule: **answers must be words taken from the passage, exactly as they appear, within the word limit.** You may not change the form of the word.

You cannot "correct" the passage's grammar.

If the passage says "the organisms *migrate*" and the sentence frame requires "the process of ____", you may not write "migrating" unless that word appears. Find a form that does appear, or reconsider your location.

Two techniques:

- 1 Predict the word class before you look.** Just as in Listening, the grammar of the gap tells you whether you need a noun, an adjective or a verb. Half of all wrong answers in this type are the right idea in the wrong word class.
- 2 Completion answers are almost always in order** and almost always concentrated in one part of the passage — find the first one, and the rest are in the following paragraphs.

Summary completion with a word box

Different rules apply. The box words are **synonyms**, not passage words. Sort the box by word class first — this typically eliminates two-thirds of the options for each gap in a single step.

3.9 Multiple choice, and multi-select

Same design logic as in Listening: the correct option is paraphrased; distractors reuse the passage's vocabulary with altered meaning.

For **multi-select** ("Choose TWO letters from A–E"), the correct options are usually in different paragraphs. Evaluate all five independently against the text rather than picking the two that feel best.

3.10 Diagram-label completion

Common in Academic Reading with a technical passage. You label parts of a device, a structure or a process.

Strategy. The passage describes the diagram in a *sequence* — usually spatial (bottom to top, outside in) or functional (input to output). Find the paragraph that describes the object, then read it with your finger on the diagram. The prepositions carry the marks: *beneath, surrounding, attached to, feeds into, is drawn off through*.

3.11 General Training Reading

Five texts across three sections, increasing in difficulty:

Section	Content	Question focus
1 — Social survival	Two or three short texts: advertisements, timetables, notices, leaflets	Factual detail, matching, T/F/NG. Speed and precision
2 — Workplace survival	Two texts: job descriptions, staff handbooks, training materials, contracts	Detail, matching, headings
3 — General interest	One long descriptive or discursive text	Full range, closest to Academic

The GT-specific skills:

- **Section 1 is a data-extraction exercise.** Prices, dates, eligibility conditions, exclusions. The traps are in words like *except, unless, only if, excluding weekends, members only*.
- **Be brutally fast in Section 1.** Ten to twelve minutes for fourteen questions. Bank the time for Section 3.
- **Remember the higher band threshold** (Chapter 1.2). You need 34/40 for Band 7 versus 30 for Academic. There is no room for careless errors in the easy sections.

3.12 Vocabulary in Reading: what to do with unknown words

You will not know every word. You do not need to.

The three-step unknown-word protocol

1. **Is it load-bearing?** If the word is not in or near an answer, skip it entirely. Most unknown words are irrelevant.
2. **If it is, use morphology.** Prefix, root, suffix. *In-* (not), *re-* (again), *sub-* (under), *-tion* (noun, process), *-ity* (noun, quality), *-ous* (adjective), *-ify* (verb, to make).
3. **Use the sentence.** Contrast markers (*but, however, whereas*) tell you the word means the opposite of something nearby. Lists tell you it belongs to a category. Appositives ("X, that is, a kind of Y") define it outright.

Example. "Unlike the gregarious starling, the shrike is a solitary hunter." You may not know *gregarious*. *Unlike + solitary* tells you it means the opposite of solitary: sociable, living in groups. That is enough.

3.13 Transfer, spelling and the answer sheet

- **Spelling counts.** A correctly located answer spelled wrongly scores zero.
- **Copy exactly,** including capitals for proper nouns.
- **Write answers on the sheet as you go,** passage by passage. Do not leave transfer to the end; candidates who do lose whole passages to the clock.
- **Number carefully.** A single misalignment can invalidate a dozen answers.
- **Never leave a blank.** For T/F/NG, guessing gives you a one-in-three chance. For matching, one in five or six. Free expected marks.

3.14 A four-week Reading training programme

Week 1 — Untimed accuracy. Do full passages with no clock. Aim for 90% accuracy. Then, for every wrong answer, find the exact words in the passage that produce the right one and write out the paraphrase relationship. This is the core learning activity.

Week 2 — Skimming and structure. Take five passages a day. Do *not* answer questions. Skim each in two minutes and write a one-line summary of each paragraph. Then check by reading properly. You are training the topic-sentence reflex.

Week 3 — Timed by passage. Twenty minutes per passage, hard stop. Accept a dip in accuracy; it will recover.

Week 4 — Full tests. Sixty minutes, three passages, transfer included, no exceptions.

The reading you do outside practice tests

Read non-fiction prose in English for thirty minutes daily: quality newspapers, popular science magazines, long-form journalism. Do not look up every word. The purpose is not vocabulary acquisition; it is building the *reading speed* and the *tolerance for uncertainty* that a timed test demands.

3.15 Reading diagnostic checklist

- I skimmed before reading any question.
- I noted a one-word topic for each paragraph.
- I underlined the keywords in every question.
- I found the answer's location before deciding the answer.
- For T/F/NG, I could point to specific words for every TRUE and every FALSE.
- I did not answer from general knowledge.
- I circled all quantifiers and modal verbs in the statements.
- I moved to the next passage at the twenty-minute mark.
- I transferred answers passage by passage.
- I left no blanks.

Chapter 4 — Academic Writing Task 1

Twenty minutes, 150 words, one third of the Writing mark: describing data without opinion

The course returns to this task repeatedly, and its treatment is unusually systematic: a fixed four-paragraph architecture, a fixed word count, a fixed time allocation, and a long list of prohibitions. What follows is that system, made complete.

4.1 The brief, and what "one third" means

You are given a visual — a graph, chart, table, diagram or map — and asked to *summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant*. You have **twenty minutes** and must write **at least 150 words**.

The three numbers that govern this task

20 minutes. Not 25. The task is worth one third of the Writing band; Task 2 is worth two thirds. Time stolen from Task 2 is expensive.

150 words minimum. Under 150 and you are penalised automatically on Task Achievement.

160–190 words is the target. The teacher is explicit: "an average of 160 up to 180 words is more than enough." Beyond about 200 you are adding risk — more sentences, more errors, less time — for no reward.

The instruction wording itself contains the entire marking scheme. *Summarise* — do not list everything. *Select* — choose what matters. *Main features* — the big movements, not the small ones. *Make comparisons* — the marks are in the relationships between the data, not in the data.

The prohibitions

No opinion. Never write "I think", "in my view", "this is worrying", "the government should". Task 1 is description. Opinion is off-task and costs Task Achievement directly.

No explanation of causes unless the visual shows them. Do not speculate why tourism rose.

No headings, no subheadings, no bullet points, no numbered lists. The teacher is emphatic on this: "Never use headings. Never use bullet points. Never use one, two, three, four, five." It must be continuous prose in paragraphs.

No idioms. Task 1 is formal academic register.

No copying the question. The introduction must be a paraphrase. Copied words are excluded from the word count and damage Lexical Resource.

4.2 The four-paragraph architecture

Every Task 1 answer uses the same structure. Internalise it so completely that you never have to think about it in the exam.

Paragraph	Function	Sentences	Approx. words
1. Introduction	Paraphrase the prompt: what, where, when, units	1–2	25–35
2. Overview	The 2–4 biggest features. No numbers.	2–3	40–50
3. Body 1	First group of detail, with figures	3–4	45–55

Paragraph	Function	Sentences	Approx. words
4. Body 2	Second group of detail, with figures	3–4	45–55

Four paragraphs. Occasionally three if the data is simple, or five if there are two distinct visuals. Never one. Never seven.

The overview is the highest-value paragraph in Task 1.

An answer with no overview is capped at **Band 5** for Task Achievement no matter how accurate the detail. The overview is where you demonstrate that you have *understood* the data rather than merely transcribed it. Write it second, immediately after the introduction, so that you cannot run out of time and omit it.

What goes in the overview

Two to four statements of the largest, most general patterns. Ask yourself:

- 1 What is the **overall trend** — is everything rising, falling, or mixed?
- 2 What is the **highest** and what is the **lowest**?
- 3 What is the **biggest change** over the period?
- 4 Is there a **crossover**, a **reversal**, or a **striking similarity**?

And what does *not* go in: specific figures. The overview is the wide shot. Save the numbers for the body paragraphs.

“Weak overview: “The graph shows that tourist arrivals in France were 60 million in 1995 and 77 million in 2010, while Egypt rose from 3 million to 14 million.” Strong overview: “Overall, all five countries experienced growth in tourist arrivals over the fifteen-year period, although the scale of this growth varied considerably. France remained by far the most popular destination throughout, whereas the most dramatic proportional increases occurred in Egypt and Malaysia.””

The second version has no figures, states three separate patterns, and uses comparison language. That is a Band 7+ overview.

4.3 Paragraph 1: the introduction

One sentence, sometimes two. It must paraphrase the question. Four elements must be changed or restated:

Element	Prompt	Your paraphrase
The visual noun	"The bar chart below shows..."	"The bar chart provided illustrates..."
The verb	"shows"	"illustrates / depicts / compares / presents / gives data on"
The topic	"the number of international tourist arrivals"	"how many overseas visitors travelled to..."
The time frame	"between 1995 and 2010"	"over a fifteen-year period from 1995 to 2010"

Verb bank for the introduction

Chart type	Verbs
Any	illustrates, shows, depicts, presents, provides information on, gives data on, compares, outlines
Trends over time	charts, traces, tracks
Process	outlines the stages by which, describes the process of

Chart type	Verbs
Map	illustrates the changes to, shows the development of

Chart-type nouns: line graph, bar chart, column chart, pie chart, table, diagram, flow chart, process diagram, map, plan.

Do not reuse the same verb twice. If the introduction says "illustrates", the overview cannot also say "illustrates". The teacher makes this point directly: "after that you need to change the verb phrase — don't use the word illustrate one more time."**

Introduction templates

- The [chart type] [verb] [paraphrased topic] [paraphrased time frame].
- The provided [chart type] compares [X] in/between [Y] over the period [Z].
- [Paraphrased topic] over [time frame] is illustrated in the [chart type].

Worked example.

"Prompt: *"The line graph below shows the number of international tourist arrivals in five countries between 1995 and 2010."* **Introduction:** *"The line graph provides data on how many overseas visitors travelled to five different nations over a fifteen-year period beginning in 1995."*

Every content word has been changed: *shows* → *provides data on*; *the number of* → *how many*; *international tourist arrivals* → *overseas visitors travelled*; *countries* → *nations*; *between 1995 and 2010* → *over a fifteen-year period beginning in 1995*.

Do not paraphrase into inaccuracy. "Fifteen-year period" is only correct if the period really is fifteen years. If the data runs 1995–2010 inclusive by decade markers, count carefully. The teacher warns: "you need to be very accurate and true about that."**

4.4 The language of change: the master bank

This is the vocabulary engine of Task 1. Learn it as **verb** + **adverb** and **adjective** + **noun** pairs, because both patterns are needed for grammatical range.

Upward movement

Verb	Noun
rise (rose, risen)	a rise
increase	an increase
grow (grew, grown)	growth
climb	a climb
go up	—
surge	a surge
soar	—
rocket	—
escalate	an escalation
double / triple / quadruple	—

Downward movement

Verb	Noun
fall (fell, fallen)	a fall
decrease	a decrease
decline	a decline
drop	a drop
dip	a dip
plunge	a plunge
plummet	—
slump	a slump
tumble	—
halve	—

Stability, fluctuation, extremes

Meaning	Language
No change	remained stable / steady / constant / unchanged; levelled off; plateaued; held steady at
Irregular movement	fluctuated; oscillated; varied; showed considerable volatility
Peak	reached a peak of; peaked at; hit a high of; reached its highest point
Trough	reached a trough of; bottomed out at; hit a low of; reached its lowest point
Recovery	recovered; rebounded; bounced back; picked up

Degree — adverbs and adjectives

Degree	Adverb (with verb)	Adjective (with noun)
Very large	dramatically, sharply, steeply, markedly	a dramatic/sharp/steep/marked rise
Large	significantly, considerably, substantially	a significant/considerable/substantial increase
Moderate	moderately, noticeably	a moderate/noticeable decline
Small	slightly, marginally, somewhat	a slight/marginal/minor fall
Steady	steadily, gradually, consistently, progressively	a steady/gradual/consistent growth
Sudden	suddenly, abruptly, rapidly, swiftly	a sudden/abrupt/rapid drop

The two grammatical patterns — use both

Pattern A (verb + adverb): *Sales rose sharply between 2001 and 2004.*

Pattern B (there + be + adjective + noun): *There was a sharp rise in sales between 2001 and 2004.*

Pattern C (noun as subject): *A sharp rise in sales occurred between 2001 and 2004.*

Alternating between these three is one of the cheapest ways to raise your Grammatical Range score. Most Band 5 scripts use Pattern A exclusively.

The synonym-grouping exercise

The course runs an exercise worth reproducing: match expressions that mean the same thing. Understanding these equivalences prevents accidental repetition.

Group	Equivalent expressions
Slow steady rise	rose steadily / increased gradually / showed a gradual upward trend / climbed progressively
Fast large rise	rose dramatically / surged / soared / increased sharply / rocketed
Slow steady fall	fell steadily / declined gradually / edged down
Fast large fall	plummeted / plunged / dropped sharply / slumped
No change	remained constant / stayed the same / showed no change / levelled off
Reached maximum	peaked at / reached a peak of / hit its highest point of
Reached minimum	reached a trough of / bottomed out at / fell to a low of

4.5 The grammar of describing data

Prepositions — the commonest error zone

Preposition	Use	Example
from ... to	start and end values	"rose <i>from</i> 20% <i>to</i> 45%"
between ... and	start and end times	" <i>between</i> 1995 <i>and</i> 2010"
by	the size of the change	"increased <i>by</i> 25 percentage points"
to	the final value	"fell <i>to</i> just 5 million"
at	a static value	"stood <i>at</i> 40%"; "peaked <i>at</i> 62"
in	year, month, season	" <i>in</i> 2004", " <i>in</i> March"
on	specific date	" <i>on</i> 3 June"
of	with a noun of change	"a rise <i>of</i> 12%"
over	duration	" <i>over</i> the period", " <i>over</i> two decades"
during	within a period	" <i>during</i> the 1990s"

"Increased by" versus "increased to"

"Sales increased **by** 20%" = sales grew, and the amount of growth was 20%.

"Sales increased **to** 20%" = sales ended at 20%.

These mean completely different things, and confusing them is a factual error, which damages Task Achievement, not just grammar.

Tense

Past data → **past simple**. "In 1995, arrivals stood at 60 million." **Ongoing/present data** → **present simple**.

"The chart shows..." **Future projections** → **future forms**. "Figures are expected to reach 90 million by 2030." / "are projected to" / "are forecast to". **Mixed periods** — switch tenses accordingly, and signal clearly.

Articles

- **The** with superlatives and specific references: *the highest figure, the period in question, the graph*.

- **A/an** with a countable noun of change: *a slight increase, a dramatic fall*.
- **No article** with plural generalisations: *tourist arrivals rose, figures for France*.

Comparatives and superlatives — the comparison marks

The instruction says "make comparisons where relevant." These are marks you must actively claim.

Structure	Example
more/less + adj + than	"France was <i>more popular than</i> any other destination."
-er than	"Egypt grew <i>faster than</i> Malaysia."
the most/least + adj	"the <i>most significant</i> increase"
by far the + superlative	" <i>by far the</i> highest figure"
twice/three times as many as	" <i>three times as many</i> visitors as Brazil"
nearly/roughly/approximately	" <i>roughly</i> twice the figure for Egypt"
whereas / while / in contrast	"France rose modestly, <i>whereas</i> Egypt more than quadrupled."
compared with / in comparison with	" <i>Compared with</i> 1995, the 2010 figure was..."
a similar pattern / likewise / similarly	"Brazil followed <i>a similar pattern</i> ."
the gap between X and Y widened/narrowed	" <i>The gap between</i> the two <i>widened</i> after 2003."

Comparison is the difference between Band 6 and Band 7 in Task 1.

A Band 6 script describes each line separately, one after another. A Band 7 script *relates* the lines to each other: which is higher, which grew faster, where they crossed, how the gap changed. Write at least three explicit comparisons in every answer.

4.6 Using figures correctly

The teacher is unambiguous: "You need to add values, you need to add percentage or numbers... you need to support that with figures."

An answer with no figures cannot exceed Band 5 for Task Achievement, because you have not reported the data. But an answer that lists every figure is equally penalised, because you have not selected. Roughly six to ten well-chosen figures across the two body paragraphs is right.**

Which figures to choose

- Start and end values for each major series.
- Peaks and troughs.
- The value at any crossover point.
- The size of the largest change.

Approximation language — use it

You rarely need exact readings, and pretending to precision you cannot have looks worse than approximating.

Approximate	Just under	Just over	Rounding
approximately	just under	just over	around

Approximate	Just under	Just over	Rounding
roughly	slightly below	slightly above	about
nearly	almost	a little more than	some
in the region of	marginally less than	in excess of	or so

"...peaked at just over 60 million in 2008 before dipping to around 55 million the following year."

Percentages versus proportions

- **per cent** (two words, British) or **percent**; the symbol % is acceptable.
- **percentage point** for a difference between percentages: from 20% to 25% is "a rise of five percentage points" or "a rise of 25%". Both are correct but they mean different things — choose deliberately.
- **Proportion / share / fraction**: "one in four", "a quarter", "a third", "two-thirds", "the majority", "a minority", "a significant proportion".

4.7 Type-by-type technique

Line graph — change over time

The default type. Structure the body paragraphs by **grouping**: put similar lines together.

- If two lines rise and two fall: Body 1 = the risers, Body 2 = the fallers.
- If one line dominates: Body 1 = the dominant line, Body 2 = the rest.
- If there are two distinct phases in time: Body 1 = phase one, Body 2 = phase two.

Model answer — line graph (Band 8).

"Prompt: The line graph shows international tourist arrivals (millions) in five countries, 1995–2010."

"The line graph provides data on the number of overseas visitors received by five nations over a fifteen-year period from 1995 to 2010.

Overall, every country under consideration saw its visitor numbers grow across the period, though the rate of expansion differed markedly between them. France was the leading destination throughout, while the most striking proportional gains were recorded by Egypt and Malaysia, both of which started from a very low base.

Beginning with the two dominant destinations, France attracted around 60 million tourists in 1995, a figure which climbed steadily to reach approximately 77 million by 2010. The USA followed a broadly similar trajectory, rising from roughly 43 million to just over 60 million, although its growth was interrupted by a noticeable dip between 2000 and 2003, after which numbers recovered.

The remaining three countries operated on a far smaller scale but grew considerably faster in relative terms. Malaysia's arrivals increased almost fivefold, from under 8 million to approximately 25 million, overtaking Brazil in 2001 and continuing to pull away thereafter. Egypt's figures more than quadrupled, climbing from some 3 million to around 14 million, whereas Brazil recorded the most modest expansion of the five, edging up from roughly 2 million to just 5 million over the entire period."

Word count: 196. Four paragraphs. Overview with no figures. Eleven figures, all approximated. Six explicit comparisons. Three grammatical patterns for change.

Bar chart — comparison between categories

If there is no time axis, you are comparing categories, so comparison language dominates and trend verbs largely disappear. Group by **size** (highest group, lowest group) or by **category type**.

Useful frames: *X accounted for the largest share, at... / At the other end of the scale... / The three remaining categories were broadly comparable, ranging from ... to ...*

Pie chart — proportions of a whole

Almost always about **share**. Key vocabulary: *accounted for, made up, constituted, represented, comprised*.

- "Housing accounted for the largest share of expenditure, at 32%."
- "Transport and food together made up nearly half of the total."
- "Entertainment represented the smallest proportion, at a mere 4%."

With **two pie charts** (two years or two groups), the task is comparison, not description. Do not describe pie 1 then pie 2. Describe what **changed**: which shares grew, which shrank, which stayed the same, whether the ranking changed.

Table — numbers in a grid

Tables often contain more data than you can report, so selection is being tested hardest here. Find the extremes: highest and lowest in each row and column, and any cell that breaks the pattern. Organise your body paragraphs by row or by column, whichever gives the cleaner story.

Process diagram — no time axis, no figures

A radically different task with its own language.

Process diagrams: the five rules

1. **Count the stages** and state the number in the overview: "The process comprises seven distinct stages, beginning with X and culminating in Y."
2. **State whether it is linear or cyclical.**
3. **Use the passive voice** throughout: "the beans *are harvested*", "the mixture *is then heated* to 180°C". The agent is irrelevant; the process is what matters.
4. **Use sequencers**, not comparison language: *initially, first of all, subsequently, following this, once X has been completed, at this point, in the final stage*.
5. **No figures, no trends, no comparisons.** These verbs do not belong here.

Sequencing bank: First / Initially / To begin with / At the first stage → Next / Then / Subsequently / Following this / After that / Once this has been done / At this point → Meanwhile / Simultaneously / At the same time → Finally / Lastly / In the final stage / The process culminates in / The cycle then repeats.

Passive forms you will need: is/are + past participle (*is collected*), is/are then + pp (*is then filtered*), having been + pp (*having been dried, the leaves are...*), before/after being + pp (*before being packaged*).

Maps — change over time in a place

Two maps of the same location at different dates. The task is **change**.

Language of development:

Change	Language
New construction	was built / was constructed / was erected; a new X was added
Removal	was demolished / was knocked down / was cleared / was removed
Conversion	was converted into / was turned into / was redeveloped as
Expansion	was extended / was enlarged / was expanded
Reduction	was reduced in size / was scaled back

Change	Language
Replacement	was replaced by / gave way to / made way for
Relocation	was relocated to / was moved to
Retention	remained unchanged / was left intact / was retained

Structure by **area** (north / south / centre) or by **type of change** (what was added / what was removed). Use compass directions and spatial prepositions constantly: *in the north-east corner, along the western edge, on the opposite bank, adjacent to, to the south of*.

Tense: **past simple passive** for a past-to-past comparison; **present perfect** if one map is "today"; **future passive** ("will be built") if one map shows a plan.

Multiple visuals

Occasionally you get two charts, or a chart and a table. Do not treat them as two separate tasks. Write one introduction covering both, one overview covering both (stating the relationship between them if there is one), then one body paragraph for each visual.

4.8 The Task 1 checklist

Run this in the last two minutes.

- Four paragraphs, clearly separated.
- Introduction paraphrases the prompt — no copied phrases.
- Overview present, labelled with "Overall," or "In general," and containing **no figures**.
- Body paragraphs contain figures, correctly read.
- At least three explicit comparisons.
- No opinion, no explanation of causes, no bullet points, no headings.
- Word count between 160 and 190.
- Tenses consistent with the time frame.
- "by" versus "to" used correctly in every change statement.
- Verbs not repeated more than twice.

4.9 Practice tasks

Task 1A. The bar chart shows the percentage of households with internet access in four countries in 2000, 2010 and 2020. Summarise the information. Write at least 150 words. 20 minutes.

Task 1B. The two pie charts show the proportion of energy generated from six sources in one country in 1990 and 2020.

Task 1C. The diagram illustrates the process by which recycled paper is produced.

Task 1D. The two maps show the town of Northfield in 1980 and today.

Task 1E. The table gives figures for average monthly rainfall and temperature in five cities.

For each: write in twenty minutes, then self-assess against the checklist in 4.8 before rewriting. The rewrite is where the learning happens.

Chapter 5 — General Training Writing

Task 1: The Letter

Twenty minutes, 150 words, three registers: getting the tone right before getting the words right

General Training candidates write a letter instead of describing data. The task looks easier than the Academic version and is scored on the same four criteria with the same weighting — one third of the Writing band. The trap is register: a letter that is technically correct but tonally wrong loses marks in every criterion at once.

5.1 The brief

You are given a situation in three or four lines, followed by **three bullet points** you must address, and an instruction about how to begin. Twenty minutes, at least 150 words.

“You recently stayed at a hotel and were dissatisfied with the service you received. Write a letter to the hotel manager. In your letter: • give details of your stay • explain what went wrong • say what you would like the manager to do Begin your letter: Dear Sir or Madam,”

All three bullets must be covered, and covered roughly equally.

Task Achievement is assessed principally on bullet coverage. Two well-developed bullets and one mentioned in passing caps you at Band 6. Give each bullet its own paragraph, and give each paragraph two to four sentences.

5.2 Register: the first decision you make

Before you write a single word, decide which of three registers applies. The prompt tells you, usually through the salutation instruction and the relationship described.

	Formal	Semi-formal	Informal
Recipient	Someone you don't know, in an official role	Someone you know in a professional or neighbourly context	Friend, family
Prompt signals	"Dear Sir or Madam"; "the manager"; "the council"	"your landlord"; "your manager, Mr Smith"; "a neighbour"	"your friend"; "Begin: Dear Tom,"
Opening	Dear Sir or Madam,	Dear Mr Hassan, / Dear Dr Lee,	Dear Tom, / Hi Sara,
Closing	Yours faithfully,	Yours sincerely,	Best wishes, / All the best, / Love,
Contractions	Never	Sparingly	Freely
Phrasal verbs	Avoid	Some	Freely
Tone	Impersonal, restrained	Polite, warm, professional	Chatty, personal

The faithfully/sincerely rule

If you begin **"Dear Sir or Madam"** (you do not know the name), you close **"Yours faithfully,"**.

If you begin **"Dear Mr Patel"** (you know the name), you close **"Yours sincerely,"**.

Getting this wrong is a small error that signals to the examiner that you have not learned the conventions. Learn it in thirty seconds and never lose the mark. *Mnemonic: you cannot be sincere with someone whose name you don't know.*

Note also: "**Dear Sir or Madam**" not "Dear Sir/Madam" in careful writing; never "Dear Madam or Sir"; never "To whom it may concern" in IELTS; never "Dear Manager".

5.3 The five-paragraph letter architecture

Paragraph	Content	Words
Salutation	Dear _____,	—
1. Purpose	Why you are writing, in one or two sentences	20–30
2. Bullet 1	Background / details	35–45
3. Bullet 2	The substance	35–45
4. Bullet 3	The request / outcome	35–45
5. Sign-off line	A closing sentence, then the complimentary close and a name	15–25

Total around 180 words, comfortably over the minimum.

Names. Sign with a name. For formal letters, invent a plain one — *James Miller, Sarah Ahmed*. Do not use your real name if you'd rather not; examiners do not care, but a blank signature looks unfinished. Do not write addresses or dates; they are not required and waste words.

5.4 Opening lines by purpose

The first sentence announces the letter's function, and examiners recognise these frames instantly as competent.

Formal openings

Purpose	Frame
Complaint	<i>I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with... / I am writing to complain about...</i>
Request	<i>I am writing to request... / I would be grateful if you could...</i>
Application	<i>I am writing to apply for the position of... advertised in...</i>
Enquiry	<i>I am writing to enquire about... / I would like to obtain further information regarding...</i>
Information	<i>I am writing to inform you that... / I am writing with regard to...</i>
Resignation	<i>I am writing to give formal notice of my resignation from...</i>
Apology	<i>I am writing to apologise for...</i>
Suggestion	<i>I am writing to propose... / I would like to suggest...</i>

Semi-formal and informal openings

Purpose	Frame
Thanks	<i>I just wanted to thank you for... / Thanks so much for...</i>
Invitation	<i>I'm writing to invite you to... / How do you fancy...?</i>
News	<i>I thought I'd drop you a line to let you know...</i>
Apology	<i>I'm so sorry about... / I really must apologise for...</i>
Request (informal)	<i>I was wondering whether you could... / Is there any chance you could...?</i>

Purpose	Frame
Advice	<i>I hear you're thinking of... — here's what I'd suggest.</i>

Never open an informal letter with "I am writing to..." It is stiff and signals you have memorised one frame for all situations. To a friend: **"It's been ages! I thought I'd write and tell you about..."**

5.5 Functional language banks

Complaining (formal)

- I was extremely disappointed to find that...
- The service fell considerably short of what I had been led to expect.
- On arrival, I discovered that...
- Despite repeated requests, the matter was not resolved.
- This caused me considerable inconvenience.
- I trust you will appreciate my frustration.

Requesting and demanding redress

Softness	Frame
Very polite	<i>I would be most grateful if you could consider...</i>
Polite	<i>I would appreciate it if you could...</i>
Neutral	<i>Could you please...</i>
Firm	<i>I would like to request a full refund.</i>
Firmer	<i>I must insist that...</i>
Firmest (still polite)	<i>I trust that you will take immediate steps to...</i>

Apologising

- Please accept my sincere apologies for...
- I am afraid I will be unable to...
- I do hope this has not caused you any inconvenience.
- I realise this is short notice and I am sorry for the disruption.

Explaining and giving reasons

- This was due to circumstances beyond my control.
- Owing to an unexpected family commitment, I...
- The reason for this is that...
- As a result of the delay, I was obliged to...

Making suggestions

- It might be worth considering...
- One possible solution would be to...
- Perhaps you could...

- I would strongly recommend that...

Closing lines

Register	Closing sentence
Formal	<i>I look forward to receiving your response at your earliest convenience.</i>
Formal	<i>I would appreciate a reply within fourteen days.</i>
Formal	<i>Thank you for your attention to this matter.</i>
Semi-formal	<i>Thank you in advance for your help with this.</i>
Semi-formal	<i>Please do let me know if you need any further information.</i>
Informal	<i>Do write back soon and let me know what you think.</i>
Informal	<i>Can't wait to hear from you!</i>
Informal	<i>Give my love to everyone at home.</i>

5.6 Model letters

Model 1 — Formal complaint (Band 8)

“You recently bought a piece of equipment for your home but it did not work. Write to the shop. In your letter: describe the item; explain the problem; say what you want the shop to do.”

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with a dishwasher purchased from your Riverside branch on 14 March, and to request that the matter be resolved without further delay.

The appliance in question is a Marlow AquaPro 600, priced at £429, which I selected on the recommendation of one of your sales assistants. It was delivered and installed by your own technicians on 20 March, and I retain both the receipt and the installation certificate.

Unfortunately, the machine has never functioned correctly. From the very first cycle it has failed to drain completely, leaving several centimetres of water in the base, and on two occasions this has overflowed onto the kitchen floor. I reported the fault by telephone on 22 March and again on 29 March, but although I was assured on both occasions that an engineer would be in touch, no one has yet contacted me.

Given that the appliance has been faulty since delivery, I would like to request a full refund rather than a repair. Should you prefer to replace the unit, I would accept an equivalent model of the same value, provided this can be arranged within the next two weeks.

I look forward to receiving your response at your earliest convenience.

Yours faithfully, James Whitfield

184 words. Three bullets in three paragraphs. Formal throughout: no contractions, no phrasal verbs, passive constructions, hedged but firm demand.

Model 2 — Semi-formal request (Band 7.5)

“You are studying a course and need to miss two weeks of classes. Write to your tutor. In your letter: explain why you will be absent; say how the absence will affect your studies; suggest how you will catch up.”

Dear Dr Okafor,

I am writing to let you know that I will unfortunately be unable to attend classes between 6 and 20 May, and to ask for your advice about how best to manage the period.

The reason for my absence is that my mother is undergoing a major operation in my home country, and as her only close relative I need to be there both for the surgery itself and for the first stage of her recovery. I appreciate that this is an inconvenient time in the term and I would not be asking if the situation were not serious.

The main difficulty is that I will miss the two seminars on research design as well as the workshop in which the group projects are allocated. I am particularly concerned about the project, since I understand that teams are formed during that session.

To minimise the disruption, I have already arranged for a classmate to record the seminars and share her notes, and I would be very willing to submit an additional written task in place of the workshop if you feel that would be appropriate. I will also have reliable internet access and could join any session remotely if that is possible.

Thank you very much for your understanding.

Yours sincerely, Amira Haddad

206 words. Semi-formal: named recipient, warmer tone, some personal explanation, still no contractions.

Model 3 — Informal letter (Band 8)

"A friend is planning to visit your city for a week. Write a letter to your friend. In your letter: say how you feel about the visit; suggest what you could do together; give some practical advice about the trip."

Dear Tom,

What brilliant news — I got your message about coming over in September and I honestly can't stop grinning. It's been nearly three years since we last saw each other properly, and a whole week is far better than the weekend I was expecting.

I've already started making plans, which you know is dangerous. The obvious thing is to spend a day walking round the old town, because it's exactly the kind of place you'd love: narrow streets, ridiculous amounts of coffee, and a market on Saturdays that sells absolutely everything. If the weather holds, we could also take the ferry across to the islands one day and swim, and I'd really like to drag you up to the observatory in the hills one evening — the view over the whole bay at sunset is genuinely something special.

A couple of practical things. Don't bother booking anywhere to stay, the spare room is yours and I'll be offended if you argue. Do bring something warm for the evenings though; it looks sunny in the photos but it gets surprisingly chilly once the sun goes down. And fly into the eastern airport rather than the main one if you can — it's twenty minutes from my flat instead of an hour and a half.

Let me know your dates as soon as you've booked and I'll take the week off work.

Can't wait!

Love, Elena

234 words. Informal: contractions throughout, phrasal verbs, exclamation, direct address, colloquial vocabulary ("brilliant", "drag you up", "can't wait").

5.7 Letter types you should have prepared

Category	Typical prompts
Complaint	Faulty goods, poor service, noisy neighbours, delayed delivery, damaged accommodation
Request	Time off, information, a reference, permission, repairs, a refund

Category	Typical prompts
Application	A job, a course, a scholarship, membership, volunteering
Invitation	A wedding, a party, a visit, a work event
Apology	Missing an event, breaking something, a cancellation, a mistake at work
Thanks	Hospitality, a gift, help during difficulty
Information	Explaining a change of plan, describing an experience, giving directions
Suggestion / proposal	Improvements to a service, an idea for a local facility, a change at work
Resignation / notification	Leaving a job, ending a tenancy, cancelling a membership

Write one of each before your exam. Nine letters, twenty minutes each — three hours of work that covers essentially the entire question bank.

5.8 Common failures and their fixes

Ten letter-writing errors

1. **Register slips** — "I am writing to complain" followed three lines later by "it was a total nightmare". Choose a register and hold it.
2. **Faithfully/sincerely mismatch**. See 5.2.
3. **Ignoring a bullet**. Every bullet gets a paragraph.
4. **Inventing too much detail** and running to 300 words. Invent enough to be specific, no more.
5. **Writing an essay**. No "In conclusion". No "Firstly, secondly, thirdly" as essay signposts.
6. **Headings or bullet points**. Continuous prose only.
7. **No paragraphing**. A wall of text is a Coherence and Cohesion penalty.
8. **Overly aggressive complaint**. "This is disgraceful and I demand compensation" reads as uncontrolled. Formal English complains coldly, not loudly.
9. **Under 150 words**. Count. The penalty is automatic.
10. **Addresses and dates at the top**. Unnecessary, and they inflate your perceived word count while contributing nothing.

5.9 Practice tasks

Task 5A (formal). You recently attended a training course that was not as described in the brochure. Write to the training provider. Include: details of the course; what was different from the description; what action you want taken. *Begin: Dear Sir or Madam,*

Task 5B (semi-formal). You want to organise a small event for colleagues at your workplace. Write to your manager. Include: what the event is; why it would be beneficial; what you need from her. *Begin: Dear Ms Rahman,*

Task 5C (informal). A friend has just moved to a new country and is finding it difficult. Write to your friend. Include: how you felt when you heard; your own experience of a similar situation; some advice. *Begin: Dear Anna,*

Task 5D (formal). You are dissatisfied with the frequency of buses in your area. Write to the transport authority. Include: which service and why you use it; the problems the current timetable causes; what change you propose.

Task 5E (semi-formal). You have been offered a job but need to delay your start date. Write to the person who offered it.

For each: twenty minutes, then check register consistency line by line. Read your letter aloud — register errors are audible long before they are visible.

Chapter 6 — Writing Task 2: The Essay

Forty minutes, 250 words, two thirds of the Writing mark: the highest-value forty minutes in IELTS

Task 2 carries **twice the weight** of Task 1. It is also the task where candidates most often plateau, because the failures are structural rather than linguistic: essays that do not answer the question, paragraphs without a controlling idea, positions that shift halfway through.

The course treats Task 2 as an engineering problem — a fixed number of paragraphs, each with a fixed function, each containing a fixed sequence of sentence types. That approach is reproduced and completed here.

6.1 The brief and the constraints

You are given a statement or question and asked to write a discursive response. **Forty minutes. At least 250 words.**

The numbers

40 minutes: 5 planning, 30 writing, 5 checking.

250 words minimum, penalised automatically below it.

260–300 words is the target. Long enough to develop; short enough to control.

Four or five paragraphs. The teacher is explicit and repeats it: writing more than five paragraphs reduces your score, and "if you write your piece of writing in one or two or even three paragraphs, you will not get more than Band 5."

The prohibitions — identical to Task 1

No headings. No subheadings. No bullet points. No numbered lists. No idioms. The teacher, writing on the whiteboard in bullets, points at his own notes: *"the way I'm writing now is called bullet points — never use something like that in your essay."*

Also: no contractions (*don't, isn't, can't*) — Task 2 is formal. No "etc." No rhetorical questions in the conclusion. No statistics you have invented ("73% of people believe...").

6.2 The five question types

Almost every Task 2 prompt belongs to one of five families. Identifying the family determines the structure, and misidentifying it is the single most common cause of a low Task Response score.

Type 1 — Opinion (Agree or Disagree)

"Some people believe that university education should be free for all students. To what extent do you agree or disagree?"

Signals: *To what extent do you agree or disagree? / Do you agree or disagree? / What is your opinion?*

Requirement: a clear, consistent position, defended throughout.

"To what extent" permits three legitimate answers:

Total agreement — "I strongly agree." Both body paragraphs support.

Total disagreement — "I firmly disagree." Both body paragraphs oppose.

Partial agreement — "I agree with respect to X, but not with respect to Y." Body 1 concedes, Body 2 argues. This is often the most sophisticated response, *provided your final position is unmistakable*.

What is **not** permitted is a balanced survey with no position. That is a different question type and scores badly here.

Type 2 — Discussion (Discuss both views and give your own opinion)

"Some people think children should start school at the age of four, while others believe seven is more appropriate. Discuss both views and give your own opinion."

Requirement: genuinely discuss both, *and* state your own view. Candidates routinely omit the opinion and lose a band.

Structure: Body 1 = view A with reasons. Body 2 = view B with reasons. Your own opinion in the introduction and the conclusion, or as a third short paragraph.

Do not give equal weight and then claim a view. If you argue side A for 100 words and side B for 100 words and then announce you favour A, you have not demonstrated why. Give slightly more development to the side you support, or add a short third paragraph justifying your choice.**

Type 3 — Problem and Solution (or Cause and Solution)

"Traffic congestion is becoming a serious problem in many major cities. What are the causes of this, and what measures could be taken to address it?"

Requirement: answer both halves. Two causes and two solutions, or one of each fully developed.

Structure: Body 1 = causes/problems. Body 2 = solutions. Make the solutions *answer* the causes; an essay whose solutions are unrelated to its stated causes is incoherent.

Type 4 — Advantages and Disadvantages

"More and more people are working from home. Do the advantages of this development outweigh the disadvantages?"

Two variants, and the difference matters:

Wording	What is required
"Discuss the advantages and disadvantages."	A balanced account. Opinion optional.
"Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?"	A verdict . You must state which side is greater and why.

The second wording appears more often, and candidates answer it as if it were the first. Read carefully.

Type 5 — Two-part question (Direct questions)

"Many people now buy goods online rather than in shops. Why is this happening? Is it a positive or a negative development?"

Requirement: answer both questions explicitly. Body 1 = question 1. Body 2 = question 2.

Reading the prompt properly

Every prompt has three parts. Separate them before planning.

Part	Function	Example
Background statement	Context. Not to be argued with.	"In many countries, the proportion of older people is steadily increasing."
The task	The actual question.	"Does this trend have more positive or negative effects?"
The instruction	Format requirements.	"Give reasons for your answer and include relevant examples from your own experience."

The commonest off-task error: answering the background instead of the task.* If the background says older populations are increasing and the task asks about effects, an essay arguing about *whether populations are ageing is off-task and capped around Band 5. Underline the task sentence. Write it at the top of your plan.

The second commonest: the hidden second question. "Why is this happening, and is it a positive development?" contains two tasks. Missing one costs a band on Task Response.

6.3 The architecture

Paragraph	Function	Sentences	Words
1. Introduction	Paraphrase + outline/thesis	2–3	40–55
2. Body 1	First main idea, fully developed	4–6	90–110
3. Body 2	Second main idea, fully developed	4–6	90–110
4. Conclusion	Restate position, summarise	2–3	35–50

A fifth paragraph is permitted where the question genuinely has three components (e.g. a third short paragraph stating your own opinion in a discussion essay). Five is the ceiling.

Two developed body paragraphs beat three thin ones.

In 280 words you can develop two ideas properly or mention four inadequately. The band descriptors reward *development* — explanation, consequence, example — not the number of ideas. This is the most common structural upgrade from Band 6 to Band 7.

6.4 The introduction, sentence by sentence

Two sentences, three at most.

Sentence 1 — Paraphrase the prompt. Restate the topic in your own words. Never copy.

Sentence 2 — The thesis statement. State your position and, ideally, signal your two main ideas.

The thesis statement

The teacher promises to "explain that in detail" and treats it as the essential element of the introduction. Here is the full account.

A thesis statement does three things: it **states your position**, it **preview your reasons**, and it **controls the whole essay** — every body paragraph must serve it.

Question type	Thesis frame
Opinion	<i>In my view, [position], principally because [reason 1] and [reason 2].</i>
Opinion (partial)	<i>While I accept that [concession], I would argue that on balance [position].</i>
Discussion	<i>Although both positions have merit, I believe that [your side] is the more persuasive, for reasons of [A] and [B].</i>
Problem/solution	<i>This essay will argue that the phenomenon stems chiefly from [cause], and that the most effective response lies in [solution].</i>
Advantages/disadvantages	<i>Although [drawback] is a genuine concern, I would contend that the benefits — notably [A] and [B] — clearly outweigh it.</i>
Two-part	<i>This essay will suggest that the trend arises from [cause], and will argue that its overall impact is [positive/negative].</i>

Avoid the mechanical announcement. "In this essay I will discuss both sides and give my opinion" tells the examiner nothing, uses fifteen words, and appears in thousands of scripts. Replace it with a thesis that has actual content.**

Also avoid the false-fact opener. "Since the dawn of time, education has been the most debated topic in the world." It is untrue, it is unoriginal, and it wastes twenty words. Start with the paraphrase.

Worked introduction.

"Prompt: "Some people believe that the internet has brought people closer together, while others argue it has made us more isolated. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.""

"The question of whether digital connectivity has strengthened or eroded human relationships continues to divide opinion. While it is undeniable that online communication can substitute for genuine contact, I would argue that on balance the internet has expanded rather than diminished our social worlds, particularly for those whose circumstances limit face-to-face interaction."

Forty-eight words. Topic paraphrased with no copied content words. Both views acknowledged. A clear position with a reason embedded. The essay now has a direction.

6.5 Body paragraphs: the PEEL engine

Each body paragraph develops **one** idea. The course's emphasis on the **topic sentence** is the key: a paragraph without one is a list of sentences, not an argument.

PEEL — the four moves of a body paragraph

P — Point (topic sentence). The controlling idea, stated in one sentence, at the start.

E — Explain. Why is this true? What is the mechanism? Two sentences.

E — Example / Evidence. A concrete instance. One or two sentences.

L — Link. Connect back to the thesis, or forward to the next paragraph. One sentence.

The topic sentence

The single most valuable sentence in the essay after the thesis. It must:

- express **one** idea, not two;
- be a **claim**, not a fact or a question;
- **relate explicitly to the thesis**;
- appear **first** in the paragraph.

Weak	Strong
"Another thing is transport."	"The most immediate benefit of investment in public transport is a measurable reduction in urban congestion."
"There are many advantages of working from home, and also disadvantages."	"Remote working delivers its clearest gains in employee autonomy."
"Why do people move to cities?"	"Economic opportunity remains the principal driver of rural-to-urban migration."

Developing the idea

Development is where Band 6 becomes Band 7. Four techniques:

- 1 Causal chain.** Push each statement one step further. *"Free tuition widens access → more first-generation students enter university → the graduate workforce becomes more socially diverse → the economic benefits of education are distributed more evenly."* Four clauses, one idea, genuine depth.
- 2 Concrete example.** "For instance, Finland's decision to abolish tuition fees was followed by a marked rise in enrolment among students from low-income households." You may invent plausible examples; they need not be verifiable, but they must be plausible and specific. Avoid invented statistics.
- 3 Consequence.** "The result is that..." / "This in turn means that..." / "The implication for policymakers is that..."
- 4 Counter and rebut.** "It might be objected that this imposes an unsustainable burden on the taxpayer. However, the fiscal cost is substantially offset by the higher lifetime tax contributions of graduates."

The listing trap. "There are many advantages. Firstly, it saves money. Secondly, it saves time. Thirdly, it is convenient. Fourthly, it is popular." Four ideas, zero development, Band 5 for Task Response. One idea, four sentences beats four ideas, four sentences** every single time.

Model body paragraph (Band 8).

"The most compelling argument for free higher education concerns social mobility. When tuition must be paid upfront or financed through substantial debt, the decision to attend university becomes a calculation about risk, and that calculation weighs far more heavily on students from low-income households than on their wealthier peers. A young person whose family has no experience of higher education, and no capacity to absorb the cost of failure, is therefore systematically less likely to apply, even when equally capable. Removing the financial barrier does not eliminate this disparity entirely, but it does remove its most concrete component. The experience of countries such as Germany, which charges no tuition at public universities, suggests that participation rates among first-generation students respond measurably to the removal of fees. In this sense, free education functions less as a subsidy than as a corrective to a market that under-serves talent."

One idea. Topic sentence, mechanism explained across three sentences, a specific example, a concluding interpretation. 145 words — slightly long, but it shows what full development looks like.

6.6 Coherence and cohesion

This criterion is 25% of the Writing band, and it is the one candidates address most crudely — by sprinkling linking words.

Coherence is logical organisation: ideas in a sensible order, one paragraph per idea, a clear line of argument from introduction to conclusion.**

Cohesion is surface linkage: the words and grammar that connect sentences — conjunctions, reference words, substitution, repetition of key terms.

You need both. Perfect cohesion in an illogical essay scores badly; perfect logic without linkage reads as a list.

The linking-word bank

Function	Formal linkers
Adding	Furthermore, Moreover, In addition, Additionally, What is more, Besides this
Contrasting	However, Nevertheless, Nonetheless, Conversely, On the other hand, By contrast, That said
Conceding	Although, Even though, While, Whereas, Admittedly, It is true that, Granted
Causing	Because, Since, As, Owing to, Due to, On account of
Resulting	Therefore, Consequently, As a result, Thus, Hence, Accordingly, For this reason
Exemplifying	For instance, For example, To illustrate, A case in point is, Such as, Namely
Sequencing	To begin with, Subsequently, Following this, Finally
Emphasising	Indeed, In particular, Notably, Above all, Crucially
Qualifying	To some extent, In certain respects, Arguably, Broadly speaking
Concluding	In conclusion, To conclude, In summary, On balance, All things considered

Overusing linkers is penalised.* *The descriptors specifically mark down "mechanical" use. A linker at the start of every sentence is mechanical. Aim for roughly one linking device per two to three sentences, and vary the position: ***"The policy, however, has proved difficult to implement"** is better than a fourth sentence-initial "However."*

Also: **"Firstly, Secondly, Thirdly, Finally"** used as the skeleton of an essay is a Band 6 signature. Use them sparingly, inside a paragraph, not as your structure.

Cohesion beyond linking words

The techniques that actually distinguish Band 7 from Band 6:

Device	Example
Reference words	"Governments have introduced congestion charging. This measure has proved effective..."
Substitution	"Some cities have banned cars from the centre; others have simply raised parking charges."
Ellipsis	"Public transport receives generous funding in northern Europe, and cycling infrastructure too ."
Lexical chains	<i>congestion</i> → <i>traffic</i> → <i>gridlock</i> → <i>vehicle volumes</i> — the same theme in varied words
Parallel structure	"Not only does it reduce emissions, but it also improves public health."
Old-to-new information flow	End each sentence with new information; begin the next with it.

The last of these is the invisible engine of good academic prose. Compare:

“Choppy: “Congestion charging reduces traffic. Air quality improves because of fewer cars. Cities like London have this system.” **Cohesive:** “Congestion charging reduces the volume of traffic entering city centres. **That reduction** translates directly into improved air quality, since fewer vehicles mean lower emissions at street level. **London**, which has operated such a scheme since 2003, offers the clearest evidence of this effect.””

6.7 The conclusion

Two to three sentences. It must:

- 1 **Restate your position** in different words from the introduction.
- 2 **Summarise your two main reasons** in compressed form.
- 3 Optionally, add a **final thought** — a recommendation or an implication.

It must **not**: introduce a new idea; contradict the introduction; ask a rhetorical question; apologise for the essay's brevity.

Conclusion frames:

- *In conclusion, while [concession], the evidence points clearly towards [position], principally because [reason 1] and [reason 2].*
- *On balance, therefore, I would maintain that [position]. [Final thought].*
- *To summarise, [restated thesis]. Unless [condition], [implication].*

Worked conclusion (for the internet essay above):

“In conclusion, although the internet is capable of substituting shallow interaction for genuine intimacy, the evidence of the past two decades suggests that it more often extends the reach of existing relationships than replaces them. The decisive factor is not the technology itself but the use to which it is put.”

6.8 Grammatical range, lexical resource, and the mistakes that cap you

Chapters 9 and 10 treat these fully. Two points belong here because they are specifically essay-level.

Sentence variety is not optional. The teacher takes an entire session on it: simple, compound and complex sentences, and the explicit warning that an essay of simple sentences “will not give you more than Band 5”. A Band 7 paragraph typically contains a short simple sentence for emphasis, one or two compound sentences, and two or three complex sentences with subordinate clauses.

Precision beats obscurity in vocabulary. Reaching for rare words you do not control produces collocation errors that damage Lexical Resource more than plain accurate language would. “A plethora of detrimental ramifications” is worse than “a range of harmful effects” if you cannot use *plethora* correctly.

6.9 Planning: the five minutes that decide the essay

The five-minute plan

Minute 1. Underline the task sentence. Identify the question type. Write it down: “DISCUSSION + OPINION”.

Minute 2. Decide your position. Write it as one sentence. This is your thesis.

Minutes 3–4. Write two topic sentences — one per body paragraph. Under each, note three words: the mechanism, the example, the consequence.

Minute 5. Check: does each topic sentence serve the thesis? Does the plan answer *every* part of the task?

Then write. Thirty minutes for roughly 280 words is nine words a minute — comfortable, if you are not also inventing the argument as you go.

A completed plan:

“TASK: Do advantages of remote work outweigh disadvantages? → VERDICT REQUIRED THESIS: Yes, on balance — autonomy + access, outweigh isolation BP1: Autonomy raises productivity → no commute, control over schedule → e.g. tech firms reporting output gains → therefore employers benefit too BP2: Widens labour market access → carers, disabled workers, rural residents → e.g. rural graduates no longer forced to relocate → social as well as economic gain CONCEDE (in BP2 or intro): isolation and blurred boundaries are real CONCLUSION: benefits structural, drawbacks manageable with policy”

6.10 Twenty essay topics to prepare

Task 2 topics recur within a limited set of domains. Prepare ideas — not memorised essays — for each.

Domain	Typical questions
Education	Free university; single-sex schools; the value of arts subjects; homework; exams vs continuous assessment; studying abroad
Technology	Social media and isolation; AI and employment; screen time and children; online vs classroom learning
Environment	Individual vs government responsibility; plastic; renewable energy costs; protecting endangered species; carbon taxes
Work	Remote working; work-life balance; job security; retirement age; gig economy
Society	Ageing populations; urbanisation; crime and punishment; equality; immigration
Health	Public vs private healthcare; junk food advertising; sport funding; mental health
Culture	Globalisation and local traditions; language extinction; tourism; museums
Government	Public spending priorities; censorship; taxation; space exploration funding

For each, write down three arguments for, three against, and one concrete example. That preparation — about four hours of work — means you will never face a Task 2 prompt with nothing to say.

6.11 A complete model essay (Band 8–9)

“Prompt: “In many countries, the gap between the rich and the poor is widening. What problems does this cause, and what measures could be taken to address it?””

Rising economic inequality has become one of the defining features of the contemporary world, and its consequences extend well beyond the balance sheets of individual households. This essay will argue that the most serious problems it generates are the erosion of social cohesion and the entrenchment of disadvantage across generations, and that progressive fiscal policy combined with sustained investment in public services offers the most realistic response.

The most corrosive effect of widening inequality is the gradual dissolution of the sense that a society is a shared enterprise. When the material circumstances of the wealthiest and the poorest diverge sufficiently, the two groups cease to use the same schools, hospitals, transport networks and public spaces, and with that separation the willingness to fund collective provision declines. A citizen who has never used a public hospital has little incentive to vote for its funding. This dynamic is self-reinforcing: as public services deteriorate, those who can afford alternatives withdraw from them, which further reduces political support for investment. The outcome is not merely inequality of income but inequality of citizenship, and it manifests in the political polarisation and declining institutional trust visible across much of the developed world.

A second and equally intractable problem is that extreme inequality tends to become hereditary. Educational attainment correlates strongly with parental income, not primarily because of innate differences but because wealthier families can purchase tutoring, housing in better catchment areas, and the freedom for their children to take unpaid internships or pursue extended study. Poverty, conversely, imposes costs that compound: insecure housing disrupts schooling, and the absence of a financial cushion forces early entry into low-paid work. Within two generations, what began as a difference in income becomes a difference in opportunity that no amount of individual effort reliably overcomes.

Addressing this requires action on both the distribution of income and the provision of services. On the fiscal side, genuinely progressive taxation — particularly of inherited wealth and unearned capital gains, which are frequently taxed more lightly than wages — would slow the accumulation of advantage at the top while generating revenue. On the expenditure side, that revenue should be directed towards the services that most powerfully equalise opportunity: early-years education, where the returns to intervention are highest; accessible healthcare; and affordable housing in areas with employment. The Nordic countries demonstrate that such an approach is compatible with economic competitiveness, having maintained comparatively low levels of inequality without sacrificing growth.

In conclusion, the widening gap between rich and poor damages societies by fracturing social solidarity and by converting temporary disadvantage into permanent exclusion. Neither problem is self-correcting, but both are susceptible to deliberate policy, and a combination of progressive taxation and well-targeted public investment represents the most credible path towards a fairer distribution of opportunity.

448 words — longer than you should write under exam conditions, and offered here as a demonstration of what full development looks like. In the exam, compress each body paragraph by a third.

6.12 The Task 2 checklist

- I identified the question type and answered **every** part of the task.
- Four (or five) paragraphs, clearly separated.
- Introduction paraphrases the prompt — no copied phrases.
- A thesis statement with a clear position.
- Each body paragraph opens with a topic sentence expressing one idea.
- Each body paragraph explains, exemplifies and links.
- My position in the conclusion matches my position in the introduction.
- No new ideas in the conclusion.
- Linkers varied, not mechanical, not sentence-initial every time.
- A mixture of simple, compound and complex sentences.
- No contractions, no bullet points, no headings, no idioms, no invented statistics.
- Between 260 and 300 words.
- Five minutes spent checking articles, plurals, subject-verb agreement and tense.

6.13 Practice tasks

6A (Opinion). *Some people believe that governments should invest in public transport rather than building new roads. To what extent do you agree or disagree?*

6B (Discussion). *Some argue that children benefit from having a wide range of activities outside school, while others believe unstructured free time is more valuable. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.*

6C (Problem/Solution). *An increasing number of people in cities are living alone. What are the causes of this trend, and what effects does it have on society?*

6D (Advantages/Disadvantages). *Many companies now monitor their employees' activity electronically. Do the advantages of this practice outweigh the disadvantages?*

6E (Two-part). *Fewer young people are choosing to study science at university. Why might this be? What could be done to reverse the trend?*

Forty minutes each. Then rewrite each one with no time limit, consulting the checklist. Compare the two versions: the difference between them is precisely the work you need to make automatic.

Chapter 7 — Speaking

Eleven to fourteen minutes, three parts, four criteria: a conversation that is also an examination

The course devotes three full sessions to Speaking, and the teacher's framing is worth keeping in mind throughout: Speaking and Writing are the **productive** skills. "You are going to produce language, and as long as you produce language, you are going to be judged." Listening and Reading ask you to recognise; Speaking asks you to generate, in real time, under observation.

The good news is that the format is completely predictable, the topics are drawn from a finite set, and the four criteria are published.

7.1 The format

Part	Time	What happens
Introduction & ID check	~1 min	Name, ID verification. Not assessed.
Part 1 — Interview	4–5 min	Questions on 2–3 familiar topics: home, work, study, hobbies, food, weather, travel
Part 2 — Long turn	3–4 min	A cue card. 1 minute preparation, 1–2 minutes speaking, then 1–2 rounding-off questions
Part 3 — Discussion	4–5 min	Abstract questions thematically linked to the Part 2 topic

The test is recorded. It is conducted face to face (or by video call). The examiner is following a script and cannot deviate much — which means the questions are highly predictable.

7.2 The four criteria, and what they actually reward

Each criterion is worth 25%.

Fluency and Coherence

Not speed. **Fluency** is the ability to keep going without unnatural pausing, excessive self-correction or constant hesitation. **Coherence** is whether your ideas connect logically and are marked with appropriate discourse signals.

Band	Description
5	Usually maintains flow but with repetition, self-correction and slow speech; over-uses simple connectives
6	Willing to speak at length, though coherence may be lost through hesitation or repetition; uses a range of connectives, sometimes inaccurately
7	Speaks at length without noticeable effort; some hesitation is language-related but occasional; uses a range of connectives flexibly
8	Fluent with only occasional repetition or self-correction; hesitation is content-related, not language-related; develops topics coherently

The critical distinction at Band 7+: hesitation is content-related, not language-related.

Pausing to think about *what* to say is normal and human, and is not penalised. Pausing because you are hunting for a word is penalised. This is why fillers matter — they let you buy thinking time without silence.

Lexical Resource

Range, precision, appropriacy, collocation, and the ability to **paraphrase** when the exact word is missing.

Grammatical Range and Accuracy

Variety of structures (not just accuracy) and how often errors occur. A candidate who speaks only in simple sentences with no errors cannot reach Band 7; range is half the criterion.

Pronunciation

Intelligibility, individual sounds, word stress, sentence stress, intonation, connected speech. Chapter 11 treats this in full.

Accent is not assessed.

The teacher is direct on this: knowing both American and British accents is useful background knowledge, "but it is not the important point." You are not required to sound British, American or Australian. You are required to be **intelligible**, to place stress correctly, and to use intonation that supports meaning. A strong regional accent that is clearly understood scores well; a "neutral" accent with misplaced word stress does not.

7.3 Part 1 — the interview

Four to five minutes, three topics, roughly four questions each. The examiner is warming you up and sampling your everyday language.

The single most damaging Part 1 habit: the short answer.

Examiner: Do you live in a flat or a house?

Candidate: I live in a house.

The teacher's response to exactly this in class: "Is that a good answer? In a speaking test, never, never give a short answer — never. You need to support your answer with details or reasons."

A four-word reply to a five-second question wastes 8% of your Part 1 time and demonstrates nothing. You have given the examiner no language to assess.

The 2–3 sentence rule

Every Part 1 answer should last **20–40 seconds** and contain:

- 1 **The direct answer.**
- 2 **A reason or detail.**
- 3 **An extension** — an example, a contrast, a personal note, or a qualification.

Rebuilt:

"I live in a house, actually — it's on the outskirts of the city, about twenty minutes from the centre. I like it a lot because it's quite modern and cosy, and there's a small garden at the back where I spend most of my free time reading when the weather allows. I did live in a flat while I was studying, but I found it a bit cramped after a while."

Three sentences. A direct answer, two reasons, a contrast with a past situation, a relative clause, a *when*-clause and a *while*-clause. That is roughly thirty-five seconds and it is Band 7+ material — from an entirely ordinary question.

But do not over-extend either. A ninety-second answer to "Do you like coffee?" is a different error: the examiner has a script to get through and will interrupt you, which breaks your rhythm. Twenty to forty seconds. Then stop and let them ask the next one.**

Extension techniques

Technique	Example
Give a reason	"...mainly because it's so much quieter than where I grew up."
Give an example	"...for instance, last weekend I spent the whole Sunday out there."
Contrast with the past	"...though I used to hate it when I was younger."
Contrast with others	"...unlike most of my friends, who'd much rather be in the city centre."
Add a condition	"...at least when the weather's good; in winter it's a different story."
Add a feeling	"...which I find genuinely relaxing after a long day."
Qualify	"...well, most of the time, anyway."
Speculate	"...I imagine I'll feel differently once I have children."

Learn two or three of these so thoroughly that they are automatic. They turn any four-word answer into a thirty-second one.

Fillers: the legitimate ones

The course recommends fillers explicitly as a way to "pave the way" for your answer and buy thinking time. Used well they *improve* fluency scores because they replace silence with natural speech.

Function	Fillers
Buying time	<i>Well..., Let me think..., That's an interesting question..., Actually...</i>
Honesty marker	<i>To be honest..., Frankly..., I must admit...</i>
Softening	<i>I suppose..., I'd say..., Sort of..., Kind of...</i>
Generalising	<i>Generally speaking..., On the whole..., More often than not...</i>
Correcting yourself	<i>Or rather..., What I mean is..., Let me put it another way...</i>

The fillers that hurt you

"Um", "uh", "er" — non-lexical. In quantity they read as hesitation, not as discourse management.

Repeating the question — "Do I like cooking? Well, do I like cooking..." Once is a stalling tactic; twice is a pattern.

"Yanni", "eh", and other first-language fillers. The teacher raises this directly with his class: a word from your own language dropped into English speech "out of context" is noticeable and marks you down. Even very common English words can misfire: he gives the example of a graduation speech in which "sorry, sorry" and "okay" kept appearing — familiar words, but wrong in context.

"Like" as a verbal tic, repeated every few words.

Part 1 topic bank

The topics are drawn from a short, stable list. Prepare two or three specific details for each so you are never hunting.

Category	Topics
You	Work or study; where you live; your home; your family; your daily routine; your hometown
Preferences	Food and cooking; music; films; books; sport; shopping; colours; weather and seasons
Activities	Free time; exercise; travel; social media; photography; going out; celebrations
Habits	Sleep; transport; keeping in touch; the internet; learning languages; being on time
Abstract-lite	Friends; neighbours; memory; the news; the environment; technology at home

Sample Part 1 exchanges — Band 7+ answers.

"What do you do? "I'm a community pharmacist — I work at a call centre for a pharmacy chain based in the business district. It's not the sort of pharmacy work most people picture; I spend the day advising patients over the phone rather than standing behind a counter, which I actually prefer.""

"What do you like about your job? "The variety, mostly. I speak to people from all sorts of different backgrounds every day, and no two conversations are quite the same. It can be demanding when someone's anxious about their medication, but being able to reassure them is genuinely the best part of it.""

"Do you have a large family or a small one? "It's fairly small, actually — it consists of my mother, my two brothers and me. We live in a village in the countryside, so we're surrounded by fields, which sounds idyllic and mostly is. We're all quite close, partly because there aren't many of us.""

Notice: "it consists of" — the teacher corrects a student on exactly this, from "it is consist of" to "it consists of". Small grammatical precision, repeatedly rewarded.

7.4 Part 2 — the long turn

You are handed a card, given **one minute** to prepare with paper and pencil, and asked to speak for **one to two minutes**.

"Describe a place you have visited that you would recommend to others. You should say: • where it is • when you went there • what you did there and explain why you would recommend it to others."

The structure of the card is the structure of your answer.

Three bullets plus a final "explain" prompt. That is four sections. Speak for roughly 20 seconds on each of the first three and 40–50 seconds on the last — the "explain" prompt always carries the most weight, because it requires justification rather than description.

Using the preparation minute

Do not write sentences. You cannot read them out convincingly and you will run out of time.

Write six to eight keywords, two per bullet, in a column. Then, if there is time, one connecting phrase. That's it.

"Where: Petra, southern Jordan — desert, canyon When: three years ago, April, with my brother What: walked the Siq at dawn, the Treasury, climbed to the Monastery Why: scale, silence, the reveal, unlike photos"

Twenty-five words. Enough to prevent a blank mind; not enough to tempt you into reading.

Speaking for two minutes

Two minutes is longer than it feels. The commonest failure is finishing in forty seconds and standing in silence.

The techniques that fill time honestly:

Technique	Example
Set the scene	"This was back in April three years ago, just after I'd finished my degree..."
Sensory detail	"The thing I remember most vividly is how cold it was at six in the morning, and how completely silent."
Narrative	Tell it as a story with a sequence: first, then, after that, eventually.
Compare	"I'd seen photographs, obviously, but none of them prepare you for the scale of it."
Feelings then and now	"At the time I was mostly exhausted; looking back, it's the trip I'd least want to undo."
Speculate	"If I went again, I'd stay longer and do the northern trail."
Generalise outward	"And I think that's why I'd recommend it to anyone, really — because..."

Do not memorise a speech.** Examiners hear hundreds of these and recognise them instantly — the rhythm flattens, the vocabulary jumps a level above your Part 1 answers, and the moment you are asked a follow-up question the fluency collapses. A memorised answer that does not quite match the card is also penalised on Task Response grounds.

Do adapt a prepared story. Having three or four rich personal experiences you can bend to fit different cards is legitimate and sensible. A trip, a person who influenced you, a difficult decision, a skill you learned — these can be reshaped for a large fraction of cue cards.

Cue card categories

Category	Examples
A person	Someone you admire; a friend; a teacher; a famous person; an elderly person you know; someone who helped you
A place	A city you visited; a quiet place; your ideal house; a park; a place you'd like to work
An object	A gift you received; something you bought recently; a piece of technology; a photograph
An event	A celebration; a journey; a time you were late; an achievement; a time you helped someone
An activity	A hobby; a sport; something you learned; something you do to relax
An experience	A difficult decision; a time you changed your mind; a time you waited for something
Media	A book, film, TV programme, song, website that had an impact on you

Model Part 2 answer (Band 8)

"Describe a skill you learned that was difficult at first."

"I'd like to talk about learning to swim, which I only did properly at the age of twenty-six, and which was far and away the most humiliating thing I've ever attempted.

It happened about four years ago. I'd moved to a coastal city for work and found myself in the slightly ridiculous position of living ten minutes from the sea and being genuinely frightened of it. So I signed up for adult beginners' lessons at the local pool, which took a certain amount of swallowing my pride, because the class was largely made up of people in their sixties who were considerably braver than I was.

What made it difficult wasn't the physical side, particularly. It was that I'd absorbed this idea, somewhere along the way, that I simply wasn't a person who could swim — and unlearning that took much longer than learning the actual strokes. For the first six or seven weeks I couldn't put my face in the water without panicking. My

instructor was remarkably patient about it; she never once made me feel foolish, and she broke everything down into these absurdly small steps — first just breathing out underwater, then floating for three seconds, then four.

The breakthrough came quite suddenly, as I think these things often do. One evening I realised I'd swum the length of the pool without thinking about it, and after that the fear more or less evaporated.

I'd say it taught me something beyond swimming, honestly. The lesson was that the thing standing between me and a fairly ordinary skill was almost entirely a story I'd been telling myself, and that the only way through was to be patient and slightly embarrassed for a couple of months."

Roughly two minutes. All four prompts covered. Past perfect, past continuous, relative clauses, a cleft sentence ("What made it difficult wasn't..."), conditional reflection, and a reflective conclusion. Idiomatic but not forced.

The rounding-off questions

After your long turn the examiner asks one or two short questions on the same topic. Answer briefly — a sentence or two. These are a transition, not a second long turn.

7.5 Part 3 — the discussion

Four to five minutes of abstract, analytical questions connected to the Part 2 theme. This is where Band 7 and Band 8 are separated, because the questions demand opinion, justification, comparison, speculation and evaluation — not personal description.

"Part 2 was about a skill you learned. Part 3 might ask: - Why do you think some adults are reluctant to learn new skills? - Is it better to learn practical skills or academic knowledge at school? - How has technology changed the way people acquire skills? - Do you think governments should fund adult education? Why?"

The Part 3 answer shape: Answer → Reason → Example → Balance

Answer: state your position directly.

Reason: explain the mechanism.

Example: make it concrete.

Balance: acknowledge the other side or add a qualification.

Roughly 40–60 seconds per answer. Longer than Part 1, shorter than Part 2.

Worked example:

"Why are some adults reluctant to learn new skills?"

"I think the main barrier is psychological rather than practical. **[Answer]** Adults have usually built an identity around being competent at certain things, and learning something new means being visibly bad at it in front of other people, which is uncomfortable in a way that it simply isn't for a child. **[Reason]** You see this very clearly with languages — plenty of people will happily read a grammar book alone but won't speak a word in public, because the mistakes feel exposing. **[Example]** That said, I don't think it's universal; I'd argue it has a lot to do with the culture of the workplace or community someone's in. Where making mistakes is treated as normal, adults seem far more willing to start from scratch. **[Balance]**"

Part 3 functional language

Function	Expressions
Giving opinion	I'd argue that...; It seems to me that...; My own view is that...; I'm inclined to think...
Speculating	It may well be that...; I suspect...; Presumably...; It's conceivable that...
Comparing	Compared with...; Whereas in the past...; The difference is that...

Function	Expressions
Generalising	By and large...; As a rule...; Broadly speaking...; In most cases...
Exemplifying	Take X, for instance...; A good case in point would be...
Conceding	I take the point that...; There's certainly something in that, although...; Admittedly...
Predicting	I imagine we'll see...; The likelihood is that...; If current trends continue...
Evaluating	The crucial factor is...; What matters most is...; The real question is whether...
Hedging	It rather depends on...; To some extent...; Up to a point...; More often than not...

Hedging deserves emphasis. Band 8 speakers rarely make absolute claims. "Governments should always fund adult education" is weaker English than "I'd say there's a strong case for public funding, at least where the skills in question have clear economic value." The hedge shows control of nuance and gives you grammatical structures to display.

If you don't understand the question

This is allowed and does not cost you marks — provided you handle it in English.

- "Sorry, could you rephrase that?"
- "Do you mean [X] specifically, or [Y] more generally?"
- "I'm not sure I've understood — are you asking about...?"

In Part 3 (though not Part 1) you may ask for clarification freely. What you must not do is answer a different question because you did not understand.

If you have no ideas

You are not assessed on the quality of your opinions. Any defensible position, defended, scores fully. Buy time honestly:

- "That's a difficult one. I suppose the first thing that comes to mind is..."
- "I haven't really thought about it before, but off the top of my head..."
- "I can see it from two angles, actually..."

7.6 Common Speaking failures

The nine habits that cap your Speaking band

1. **Short answers** (Part 1). Covered above. The most common of all.
2. **Memorised speeches**. Detected instantly; penalised.
3. **Answering a different question** because you misheard and didn't ask.
4. **Repeating the question verbatim** to buy time.
5. **Speaking too fast** to seem fluent. Speed is not fluency; clarity is. Rushing produces mispronunciation and swallowed endings.
6. **Nervous silence**. The teacher raises this with a student who freezes: if you get nervous, you will not do well — so practise until the format itself is boring. Speak, even imperfectly; silence scores zero.
7. **Simple sentences only**. No subordination, no range. See Chapter 9.
8. **Repeating basic vocabulary** — *good, bad, nice, thing, very*. See Chapter 10.
9. **First-language fillers** and out-of-context discourse markers.

On nerves, specifically

The course addresses this directly, because several students visibly struggle with it in the recorded sessions. Three practical points:

- 1 **The examiner is not your adversary.** They are following a script and filling in a form. Their friendliness or coolness carries no information about your score.
- 2 **Preparation converts fear into boredom.** If you have done forty mock Part 2s, the forty-first is not frightening.
- 3 **Organise before speaking.** The teacher's advice: "Don't rush the answer. There should be some ideas arranged in your mind." A two-second pause before beginning is invisible; a twenty-second stumble halfway through is not.

7.7 Practising alone

You do not need a partner for most of this.

Exercise	Method
Record and review	Answer five Part 1 questions, record, listen back with a notepad. Count: short answers, fillers, repeated words, grammatical errors.
The two-minute drill	Random cue card, one minute prep, speak for two minutes to a timer. Every day. Do not stop early.
Extension drill	Take ten one-word answers you'd naturally give and expand each to thirty seconds.
Shadowing	Play twenty seconds of a native speaker, then repeat it copying rhythm and intonation exactly. Best single exercise for pronunciation and fluency together.
The opinion minute	Pick a Part 3 question at random. Speak for sixty seconds using the Answer–Reason–Example–Balance shape.
Vocabulary upgrading	Listen to your own recording; every time you hear <i>good, bad, nice, thing</i> or <i>very</i> , write a better alternative and re-record the sentence.

7.8 Speaking diagnostic checklist

- No Part 1 answer was shorter than two sentences.
- No Part 1 answer was longer than forty seconds.
- I filled the full two minutes in Part 2.
- I covered all four prompts on the cue card.
- I used at least three complex sentences per Part 3 answer.
- I used hedging language rather than absolute claims.
- I did not repeat the examiner's question back.
- I used English fillers, not first-language ones.
- I asked for clarification in English when I needed it.
- I did not rush; my word endings were audible.

Chapter 8 — Reading the Band Descriptors Like an Examiner

What the marker is actually looking at when your script is in front of them

Writing and Speaking are marked against published criteria. Most candidates have never read them. This chapter reproduces their substance and, more usefully, translates each one into a concrete instruction about what to do differently.

8.1 Writing Task 1 — Task Achievement

Band	What the descriptor says	What it means for you
5	Generally addresses the task but format may be inappropriate; recounts detail mechanically with no clear overview ; may be inaccurate	You listed every data point. You wrote no overview. Fix: write the overview, and select.
6	Addresses the requirements; presents an overview with information appropriately selected; some details may be inaccurately reported	You have an overview but it is thin, or you misread a figure. Fix: check every number; make the overview state 2–3 patterns.
7	Covers the requirements; presents a clear overview of main trends, differences or stages ; clearly presents and highlights key features but could be more fully extended	Your overview works. Fix: extend the body — add comparisons and consequences of the data pattern.
8	Covers all requirements sufficiently; presents, highlights and illustrates key features clearly and appropriately	Selection is precise, comparisons explicit, figures well chosen.

The word "overview" appears in every band above 5 and is absent from Band 5.** That is the clearest signal in the entire descriptor set. No overview, no Band 6.

8.2 Writing Task 2 — Task Response

Band	Descriptor substance	Your action
5	Addresses the task only partially; format may be inappropriate; expresses a position but development is unclear; some main ideas but limited/irrelevant/repetitive	You answered part of the question, or you listed ideas without developing them. Fix: underline every part of the task; develop two ideas fully rather than four thinly.
6	Addresses all parts, though some more fully than others; presents a relevant position although conclusions may become unclear or repetitive; presents relevant main ideas but some inadequately developed	Fix: equalise paragraph development; make sure your conclusion restates rather than repeats.
7	Addresses all parts; presents a clear position throughout ; presents, extends and supports main ideas, though there may be a tendency to over-generalise or supporting ideas may lack focus	Fix: replace general claims with specific mechanisms and examples.

Band	Descriptor substance	Your action
8	Sufficiently addresses all parts; presents a well-developed response with relevant, extended and supported ideas	Every paragraph has a mechanism, an example and a consequence.

8.3 Coherence and Cohesion (both tasks)

Band	Descriptor substance	Your action
5	Some organisation but no clear progression; inadequate, inaccurate or over-use of cohesive devices ; may be repetitive; may not write in paragraphs or use them inadequately	Fix: paragraph properly; cut half your linkers.
6	Arranges information coherently with clear overall progression; uses cohesive devices effectively but cohesion within/between sentences may be faulty or mechanical ; may not always use referencing clearly	Fix: vary linker position; use reference words (this, such, the latter) instead of another "Furthermore".
7	Logically organises information with clear progression; uses a range of cohesive devices appropriately though there may be some under-/over-use; presents a clear central topic within each paragraph	Fix: ensure every paragraph has one controlling idea stated in its topic sentence.
8	Sequences information and ideas logically; manages all aspects of cohesion well; uses paragraphing sufficiently and appropriately	Cohesion is invisible — it reads naturally.

"Over-use of cohesive devices" appears at Band 5.* Candidates who have been told "use linking words" often use one per sentence and score *lower for it. Cohesion that draws attention to itself is mechanical cohesion.

8.4 Lexical Resource

Band	Descriptor substance	Your action
5	Limited range, minimally adequate; noticeable errors in spelling/word formation that may cause difficulty	Fix: build topic vocabulary sets; check word forms.
6	Adequate range for the task; attempts less common vocabulary with some inaccuracy; some errors in spelling/word formation but they do not impede communication	Fix: learn collocations, not isolated words.
7	Sufficient range to allow flexibility and precision ; uses less common lexical items with some awareness of style and collocation; may produce occasional errors	Fix: focus on precision — the exact right word, not the rarest one.
8	Wide resource, fluently and flexibly conveying precise meanings; skilful use of uncommon items though occasional inaccuracies; rare errors in spelling/word formation	Idiom used naturally; register consistently controlled.

"Flexibility and precision" at Band 7 — not rarity.

Using *ameliorate* where *improve* was needed is not Band 7 vocabulary; it is a collocation error. Using *mitigate* correctly with *risk*, *impact* or *effect* is. Learn words inside their collocations or do not use them.

8.5 Grammatical Range and Accuracy

Band	Descriptor substance	Your action
5	Limited range; attempts complex sentences but these are less accurate than simple ones; frequent grammatical errors that may cause some difficulty	Fix: master two complex structures properly before attempting more.
6	Mix of simple and complex forms; some errors in grammar and punctuation but they rarely reduce communication	Fix: increase the proportion of complex sentences; check articles and agreement.
7	A variety of complex structures; majority of sentences error-free ; good control of grammar and punctuation with a few errors	Fix: proofread for the recurring error — usually articles, plurals or subject-verb agreement.
8	Wide range of structures; the majority of sentences are error-free ; only occasional errors or inappropriacies	Relative clauses, conditionals, participles, inversions all used naturally.

The two halves — range and accuracy — are equally weighted and pull against each other. Candidates aiming for range make more errors; candidates aiming for accuracy write simply. Band 7 requires you to attempt complexity **and** control it, which is why Chapter 9 focuses on a small number of structures practised to automaticity.

8.6 Speaking descriptors

Fluency and Coherence

Band	Substance
5	Usually maintains flow but uses repetition, self-correction and slow speech to keep going; may over-use simple connectives; some breakdown in coherence
6	Willing to speak at length though may lose coherence through hesitation, repetition or self-correction; uses a range of connectives but not always appropriately
7	Speaks at length without noticeable effort ; some language-related hesitation or repetition; uses a range of connectives and discourse markers with some flexibility
8	Speaks fluently with only occasional repetition or self-correction; hesitation is usually content-related ; develops topics coherently and appropriately

Lexical Resource (Speaking)

Band	Substance
5	Manages to talk about familiar and unfamiliar topics but uses vocabulary with limited flexibility; attempts paraphrase with mixed success
6	Has a wide enough vocabulary to discuss topics at length and make meaning clear despite inappropriacies; generally paraphrases successfully

Band	Substance
7	Uses vocabulary resource flexibly to discuss a variety of topics; uses some less common and idiomatic vocabulary with some awareness of style and collocation; uses paraphrase effectively
8	Uses a wide resource readily and flexibly to convey precise meaning; uses less common and idiomatic vocabulary skilfully ; uses paraphrase effectively as required

Note that **idiomatic language** appears explicitly at Band 7 for Speaking, whereas idioms are discouraged in Writing. The registers differ. *"It's not really my cup of tea"* is a Band 7 signal in Speaking and a register error in a Task 2 essay.

Grammatical Range and Accuracy (Speaking)

Band	Substance
5	Produces basic sentence forms with reasonable accuracy; limited range of complex structures, usually containing errors
6	Uses a mix of simple and complex structures with limited flexibility; may make frequent mistakes in complex structures though these rarely cause comprehension problems
7	Uses a range of complex structures with some flexibility; frequently produces error-free sentences though some grammatical mistakes persist
8	Uses a wide range of structures flexibly; majority of sentences error-free with only occasional inappropriacies or basic/non-systematic errors

Pronunciation

Band	Substance
5	Uses a limited range of pronunciation features with mixed control; shows some effective use but this is not sustained; can generally be understood though mispronunciation reduces clarity at times
6	Uses a range of pronunciation features with mixed control; shows some effective use but with lapses; generally understood throughout , though mispronunciation of individual words or sounds reduces clarity at times
7	Shows all the positive features of Band 6 and some of Band 8
8	Uses a wide range of pronunciation features; sustains flexible use with only occasional lapses; easy to understand throughout ; L1 accent has minimal effect on intelligibility

Band 8 says "L1 accent has minimal effect on intelligibility" — not "no accent".

Having a first-language accent is compatible with Band 9. Having word stress in the wrong place, or dropping consonant clusters so that words become unrecognisable, is not.

8.7 Self-assessment: marking your own work honestly

Marking your own writing is difficult because you know what you meant. Three techniques that make it possible:

1. Mark for one criterion at a time. Read your essay four times, looking only for Task Response, then only for Coherence, then Lexis, then Grammar. Mixed-criterion reading produces an overall impression, which is exactly what you cannot trust.

2. Use the descriptor language as questions.

- Is there a *clear position throughout*? Point to the sentences that establish it.
- Is each idea *extended and supported*? Point to the mechanism and the example.
- Are the *majority of sentences error-free*? Count them. Literally count.

3. **Leave it 24 hours.** You cannot proofread your own prose on the day you wrote it.

The error log

Keep one from today. Three columns: **the error**, **the correction**, **the rule**.

Error	Correction	Rule
"The people is happy"	"The people are happy"	<i>people</i> is plural
"informations"	"information"	uncountable
"discuss about"	"discuss"	transitive, no preposition
"In nowadays"	"Nowadays"	no preposition
"He suggested me to go"	"He suggested that I go"	<i>suggest</i> + that-clause

After four weeks you will find that 80% of your errors are five or six recurring patterns. Fixing six patterns is achievable; fixing "my grammar" is not.

Chapter 9 — Grammar for Range and Accuracy

The structures that raise bands, and the errors that hold them down

Grammatical Range and Accuracy is 25% of both Writing and Speaking — a full eighth of your overall band. The criterion has two halves that pull in opposite directions, and the course teaches them in exactly the right order: first learn the three sentence types, then learn what to do inside each.

9.1 The three sentence types

This is the backbone of the grammar teaching in the course, and the message is blunt: an answer made of simple sentences "will not give you more than Band 5."

Simple sentences

One independent clause. One subject, one finite verb, a complete thought.

"The internet has transformed education. Pollution levels rose sharply after 1995."

Simple sentences are not bad. A short simple sentence after two long complex ones creates emphasis and rhythm. But an essay built only from them demonstrates no range.

Compound sentences

Two independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction. Each half could stand alone.

The seven coordinators are remembered as **FANBOYS** — a mnemonic the course uses explicitly:

Letter	Conjunction	Function
F	for	reason (formal, literary)
A	and	addition
N	nor	negative addition
B	but	contrast
O	or	alternative
Y	yet	contrast (despite expectation)
S	so	result

Punctuation rule: a comma goes BEFORE the FANBOYS conjunction when it joins two independent clauses.

*The internet offers enormous benefits, **but** it also carries significant risks.*

No comma when the conjunction joins two verbs with one subject:

*The internet offers enormous benefits **but** carries significant risks.*

Building a compound sentence — worked example from the course:

*"Simple 1: The internet has many advantages. Simple 2: The internet has some drawbacks. Compound: The internet has many advantages, **but** it also has some drawbacks."*

Note: the second clause needs its own subject. Writing *"The internet has many advantages, but the internet has some drawbacks"* is repetitive; the pronoun **it** is required. This exact correction appears in the classroom.

Comma splice — joining two independent clauses with only a comma — is an error at every band.**

✗ *The internet has many advantages, it also has drawbacks.*

✓ *The internet has many advantages, but it also has drawbacks.* (coordinator)

✓ *The internet has many advantages; it also has drawbacks.* (semicolon)

✓ *The internet has many advantages. It also has drawbacks.* (full stop)

✓ *Although the internet has many advantages, it also has drawbacks.* (subordination)

Complex sentences

One independent clause plus at least one dependent (subordinate) clause. The dependent clause cannot stand alone.

“Although the internet has many advantages, it also carries risks. Students who receive early support are more likely to complete their studies. If governments invested more in prevention, healthcare costs would fall.”

The course spends real time on the distinction, because students find it slippery:

How to test for a dependent clause

Read the clause aloud on its own. Does it feel finished?

"He studied hard" — finished. Independent.

"Although he studied hard" — unfinished; you are waiting for something. Dependent.

The subordinating word (*although, if, because, when, who, which, that...*) is what makes it dependent. Remove it and the clause becomes independent.

The subordinators

Relationship	Subordinators
Contrast/concession	although, though, even though, whereas, while
Reason	because, since, as, given that, in that
Purpose	so that, in order that
Condition	if, unless, provided that, as long as, in case
Time	when, while, before, after, until, as soon as, once, by the time
Result	so ... that, such ... that
Manner	as, as if, as though
Place	where, wherever
Relative	who, whom, whose, which, that, where, when

A dependent clause alone is a sentence fragment.

✗ *Although the policy was expensive.*

✓ *Although the policy was expensive, it proved effective.*

Fragments are marked as errors and are common in candidates who are trying to use subordination for the first time.

Comma rule for complex sentences: if the dependent clause comes **first**, use a comma. If it comes **second**, usually no comma. *Although it rained, we went out.* / *We went out although it rained.*

Compound-complex

Two independent clauses plus at least one dependent. Useful occasionally; do not build a whole essay from them.

“Although online learning offers flexibility, many students struggle with isolation, and completion rates remain stubbornly low.”

9.2 Concession structures: despite, in spite of, although, however

The course devotes an extended sequence to this cluster, because students systematically confuse them. The rule is purely grammatical: **what follows each one?**

Expression	Followed by	Example
although / even though / though	a clause (subject + verb)	<i>Although he studied hard, he failed.</i>
despite / in spite of	a noun, pronoun or -ing form	<i>Despite studying hard, he failed. / Despite his hard work, he failed.</i>
despite the fact that / in spite of the fact that	a clause	<i>Despite the fact that he studied hard, he failed.</i>
however / nevertheless / nonetheless	a new sentence (or after a semicolon)	<i>He studied hard. However, he failed. / He studied hard; however, he failed.</i>
but / yet	a clause , after a comma	<i>He studied hard, but he failed.</i>
whereas / while	a clause (contrasting two things)	<i>Whereas urban areas grew, rural areas declined.</i>

The three commonest errors in this cluster

✗ *Despite he studied hard, he failed.* → **despite + noun/-ing**, never a clause.

✓ *Despite studying hard... / Despite the fact that he studied hard...*

✗ *Although he studied hard, but he failed.* → never use **although** and **but** together. One subordinator per relationship.

✗ *He studied hard, however, he failed.* → **however** cannot join two clauses with commas. This is a comma splice.

✓ *He studied hard; however, he failed. / He studied hard. However, he failed.*

Transformation drill. Express the same idea five ways:

- 1 *Although John studied hard, he did not achieve a high score.*
- 2 *John studied hard; however, he did not achieve a high score.*
- 3 *Despite studying hard, John did not achieve a high score.*
- 4 *In spite of his hard work, John did not achieve a high score.*
- 5 *John studied hard, yet he did not achieve a high score.*

Being able to produce all five on demand is worth a great deal in both Writing and Speaking. Practise until it is instant.

9.3 Relative clauses

The highest-value complex structure, because they let you add information without starting a new sentence.

Type	Punctuation	Example
Defining (identifies which one)	No commas	Students who miss the deadline will be penalised.
Non-defining (adds extra information)	Commas	My brother, who lives in Dubai , is a pharmacist.

The relative pronouns: *who* (people), *which* (things), *that* (people or things, defining only), *whose* (possession), *where* (places), *when* (times), *why* (reasons).

Three upgrades worth learning

1. **Quantifier + of which/whom:** *The survey questioned 400 residents, **most of whom** reported dissatisfaction.*

2. **Preposition + which (formal):** *This is the framework **within which** the policy operates.*

3. **Reduced relative clauses:** drop *who/which* + *be*.

*The policies **which were introduced** in 2010 → The policies **introduced** in 2010.*

*Students **who are living** abroad → Students **living** abroad.*

Reduced relatives are compact, sophisticated and very common in academic prose.

- Do not use **that** in a non-defining clause. ✗ *My brother, that lives in Dubai...*

- Do not double the subject. ✗ *The man who he called me...* ✓ *The man who called me...*

- **Whose** is for possession by people *and* things: *a policy whose effects are unclear.*

9.4 Conditionals

Essential for Task 2 (speculation, recommendation) and Part 3 Speaking.

Type	Form	Use	Example
Zero	If + present, present	General truth	<i>If temperatures rise, ice melts.</i>
First	If + present, will/may/might + inf	Real future possibility	<i>If governments act now, emissions will fall.</i>
Second	If + past, would/could/might + inf	Hypothetical present/future	<i>If governments invested more, emissions would fall.</i>
Third	If + past perfect, would have + pp	Unreal past	<i>If they had acted earlier, the crisis would have been avoided.</i>
Mixed	If + past perfect, would + inf	Past condition, present result	<i>If they had acted earlier, we would not be in this position.</i>

Alternatives to "if" — range markers:

- *Unless action is taken...* (= if ... not)
- *Provided that / As long as funding continues...*
- *Should governments fail to act...* (inversion, formal — no "if")
- *Were the policy adopted...* (inversion of second conditional)
- *Had they acted sooner...* (inversion of third conditional)
- *In the event of a downturn...*
- *Suppose that...*

The three inverted forms are strong Band 8 signals. Learn one and use it once.

9.5 Passive voice

Essential for Task 1 process diagrams, useful throughout academic writing where the agent is unimportant.

Form: be + past participle.

Tense	Active	Passive
Present simple	They collect the data	The data is collected
Past simple	They collected the data	The data was collected
Present perfect	They have collected	The data has been collected
Past perfect	They had collected	The data had been collected
Future	They will collect	The data will be collected
Modal	They must collect	The data must be collected
-ing	—	<i>After being collected, the data...</i>
Perfect participle	—	<i>Having been collected, the data is then...</i>

Use the passive when: the agent is unknown, obvious or irrelevant; you want to keep the topic at the front of the sentence; you are describing a process.

Do not overuse it. Whole essays in the passive read as evasive and are harder to follow. Roughly one passive in five or six sentences is natural in academic prose. In a process diagram description, the proportion is far higher — that is the exception.**

9.6 Tenses: the ones that matter

You do not need all twelve. You need these six used accurately and a couple of others for range.

Tense	Use in IELTS	Example
Present simple	General truths, habits, chart descriptions	<i>The graph shows...; I work as a pharmacist.</i>
Present continuous	Current temporary situations, changing trends	<i>More people are working remotely.</i>
Present perfect	Action with present relevance; unfinished time	<i>Technology has transformed education.</i>
Present perfect continuous	Duration up to now	<i>I have been studying English for six years.</i>
Past simple	Finished past actions, completed data periods	<i>Arrivals rose between 1995 and 2010.</i>
Past continuous	Background action interrupted	<i>I was living in Cairo when I first took the test.</i>
Past perfect	Earlier past	<i>By 2005, numbers had already doubled.</i>
Future forms	Predictions, projections	<i>Figures are projected to reach...</i>

The present perfect, explained properly — because it is the tense the course spends most time correcting.

Use *have/has* + *past participle* to talk about an action **without specifying when**, where the result matters now.

I have bought a car. — I own a car now. The time is irrelevant.

I bought a car last week. — A specific finished time. Present perfect is impossible here.

✗ *I have bought a car last week.* — **Never** combine present perfect with a finished time expression.

Signal words for present perfect: *ever, never, already, yet, just, so far, recently, since, for, over the past decade.*

Signal words for past simple: *yesterday, last year, in 2010, ago, when I was young.*

9.7 Articles: a, an, the, zero

The commonest error in the scripts of otherwise strong candidates, especially those whose first language has no article system.

Use	Rule	Example
a / an	Singular countable, first mention, non-specific	<i>I saw a film last night.</i>
the	Specific, already mentioned, unique, superlative, defined by a phrase	<i>The film I saw was excellent.</i>
the	Unique things	<i>the government, the environment, the internet, the sun</i>
zero	Plural or uncountable generalisations	<i>Children learn quickly. / Education is a right.</i>
the	Specific group	<i>The children in my class learn quickly.</i>

The generalisation rule, which fixes half of all article errors:

To generalise about a category, use **plural with no article**.

✓ *Cars cause pollution.*

✗ *The cars cause pollution.* (means specific cars)

✗ *Car causes pollution.* (ungrammatical)

For uncountable generalisations, also no article: *Pollution is a problem.* Not *The pollution is a problem* unless you mean specific pollution.

Fixed expressions to memorise: *in the morning / at night; go to school / to the school* (as a building); *play the piano / play football; in hospital (BrE) / in the hospital (AmE); the rich, the poor, the elderly; by car, on foot; the number of X is / a number of X are.*

9.8 Subject–verb agreement

Trap	Wrong	Right
Intervening phrase	<i>The number of students are rising</i>	<i>The number ... is rising</i>
"A number of"	<i>A number of students is...</i>	<i>A number of students are...</i>
Uncountables	<i>Informations are...</i>	<i>Information is...</i>
Collective nouns	—	<i>The government has decided</i> (BrE also allows <i>have</i>)
Each/every	<i>Each of the students have...</i>	<i>Each of the students has...</i>

Trap	Wrong	Right
Neither/either	<i>Neither of them are...</i>	<i>Neither of them is...</i> (formal)
There is/are	<i>There is many reasons</i>	<i>There are many reasons</i>
Percentage	—	<i>40% of the population is/are...</i> (depends on the noun)

9.9 Countable and uncountable nouns

Uncountable nouns take no plural -s and no *a/an*. The list that causes almost all IELTS errors:

information, advice, research, knowledge, equipment, furniture, luggage, traffic, money, news, progress, evidence, work, accommodation, transport, staff, weather, homework, software, feedback, damage, behaviour, pollution

X informations, advices, researches, equipments, furnitures, an advice ✓ a piece of information, a piece of advice, a piece of research, an item of equipment

Quantifiers that go with each:

Countable	Uncountable	Both
many, few, a few, fewer, several, a number of	much, little, a little, less, a great deal of, an amount of	some, any, a lot of, plenty of, most, all, no

Fewer cars (countable) but *less traffic* (uncountable).

9.10 The twenty-five most common errors

#	Wrong	Right
1	discuss about	discuss
2	in nowadays	nowadays
3	according to me	in my view
4	the peoples are	people are
5	informations / advices	information / advice
6	more better	better
7	I am agree	I agree
8	He suggested me to go	He suggested that I go / suggested going
9	I am interesting in	I am interested in
10	despite of	despite / in spite of
11	although ... but	although ... [no but]
12	since 5 years	for 5 years
13	I have seen him yesterday	I saw him yesterday
14	the 90's decade	the 1990s
15	one of the reason	one of the reasons
16	every students	every student

#	Wrong	Right
17	make a research	do research / conduct research
18	most of people	most people / most of the people
19	in the other hand	on the other hand
20	depend of	depend on
21	consist of → <i>is consist of</i>	consists of
22	married with	married to
23	explain me	explain to me
24	the both	both
25	comprised of	comprises / is composed of

9.11 Punctuation

Mark	Rule
Full stop	Ends a sentence. If you are unsure about a long sentence, break it.
Comma	After an introductory phrase or clause; before FANBOYS joining independent clauses; around non-defining relative clauses; separating list items. Never joining two independent clauses alone.
Semicolon	Joins two closely related independent clauses; before a conjunctive adverb (; <i>however</i> ,). Use once or twice per essay, correctly.
Colon	Introduces a list, explanation or elaboration. <i>There is one solution: investment.</i>
Apostrophe	Possession (<i>the government's policy, students' results</i>). Not for plurals. Avoid contractions entirely in Task 1 and 2.
Capital letters	Sentence starts, proper nouns, nationalities, languages, months, days. Not for emphasis.

9.12 Ten structures to make automatic

Practise these until you can produce them without thinking. Each is a range marker.

- Not only ... but also (with inversion):** *Not only does remote work reduce commuting, but it also widens access to employment.*
- Cleft sentence:** *What matters most is not the technology itself but how it is used.*
- Reduced relative:** *Policies introduced in the last decade have had mixed results.*
- Perfect participle:** *Having reviewed the evidence, the committee recommended reform.*
- Inverted conditional:** *Were governments to invest more, outcomes would improve.*
- The more ... the more:** *The more accessible education becomes, the greater the economic return.*
- Concessive fronting:** *While the costs are considerable, the long-term benefits are greater.*
- Passive with modal:** *Greater emphasis should be placed on prevention.*
- Noun phrase subject:** *The rapid expansion of urban populations has placed pressure on infrastructure.*
- Conditional with unless:** *Unless significant action is taken, the trend is likely to continue.*

Write each one about five different topics. Twenty minutes a day for a week and they become part of your active grammar.

Chapter 10 — Vocabulary, Collocation and Paraphrase

Precision over rarity: building a lexical resource that actually raises bands

The course returns to one word more often than almost any other: **paraphrase**. It is the mechanism of Reading, the mechanism of Listening, the requirement of every Writing introduction and the marker of Band 7 in Speaking. This chapter treats paraphrase as a skill to be built, and the vocabulary around it as a tool kit.

10.1 What Lexical Resource actually measures

Four things, in descending order of importance for most candidates:

- 1 **Precision** — the exact word for the meaning.
- 2 **Collocation** — words used with their natural partners.
- 3 **Appropriacy** — the right register for the task.
- 4 **Range** — variety, including some less common items.

Note that range is fourth. Candidates almost always attack it first, and that is why so many essays contain expensive words used wrongly.

The rare-word trap. A Band 6 candidate writes: "A plethora of individuals espouse the notion that ubiquitous technology engenders deleterious ramifications."**

Every word is "advanced". The sentence is unreadable, two collocations are wrong, and the register is grotesque. It scores **lower** than: *"Many people believe that the spread of technology has harmful effects."*

The descriptor says "flexibility and precision", not "obscurity".

10.2 Collocation: the real unit of vocabulary

Words travel in groups. Learning a word without its partners produces sentences that are technically correct and audibly wrong.

Wrong	Right
make a research	conduct/do research
do a mistake	make a mistake
say a lie	tell a lie
strong rain	heavy rain
big problem (weak)	serious/major/pressing problem
high experience	extensive/considerable experience
take a decision (BrE ok) / do a decision	make a decision
gain weight ✓ / win weight ✗	gain/put on weight
pay attention on	pay attention to
discuss about	discuss
reach to a conclusion	reach a conclusion

Wrong	Right
fulfil the requirements ✓	—

High-value academic collocations

Verb	Common objects
address	an issue, a problem, a concern, the needs of
implement	a policy, a scheme, measures, reforms
impose	restrictions, a ban, a tax, sanctions, a burden
raise	awareness, standards, concerns, revenue, questions
pose	a threat, a risk, a challenge, a question
undergo	a change, treatment, training, a transformation
exacerbate	a problem, inequality, tensions
mitigate	the effects, the impact, the risk, the damage
allocate	funds, resources, time
generate	income, employment, interest, debate
undermine	confidence, an argument, efforts, trust
foster	creativity, cooperation, growth, independence
curb	pollution, spending, crime, inflation
alleviate	poverty, suffering, pressure, congestion

Adjective	Common nouns
significant	increase, impact, proportion, difference
substantial	investment, evidence, improvement, majority
widespread	belief, poverty, use, criticism
compelling	argument, evidence, case, reason
detrimental	effect, impact, consequences (+ to)
viable	alternative, solution, option
sustainable	growth, development, practices
profound	impact, change, implications
negligible	effect, difference, cost
inevitable	consequence, outcome, result

10.3 Upgrading basic vocabulary

The five words that most damage Speaking and Writing bands: **good, bad, thing, very, a lot of**.

Instead of good

Context	Better
a good idea	a sound / sensible / constructive idea
a good result	a favourable / positive / encouraging result
a good teacher	an effective / dedicated / inspiring teacher
a good film	an outstanding / compelling / absorbing film
good weather	fine / pleasant / glorious weather
a good argument	a persuasive / cogent / compelling argument
a good relationship	a close / harmonious / strong relationship

Instead of *bad*

Context	Better
a bad effect	a detrimental / adverse / harmful effect
a bad decision	a misguided / ill-advised / questionable decision
a bad situation	a dire / troubling / precarious situation
bad behaviour	disruptive / inappropriate / antisocial behaviour
a bad experience	an unpleasant / distressing / frustrating experience
bad weather	severe / inclement / atrocious weather

Instead of *very + adjective* — use one strong word

Weak	Strong
very big	enormous, vast, substantial, considerable
very small	tiny, minute, negligible, marginal
very important	crucial, vital, essential, paramount
very difficult	demanding, arduous, formidable, challenging
very good	excellent, outstanding, exceptional
very bad	appalling, dreadful, disastrous
very tired	exhausted, drained
very interested	fascinated, captivated
very hot	scorching, sweltering
very cold	freezing, bitter
very happy	delighted, thrilled, elated
very angry	furious, irate, incensed
very common	prevalent, widespread, ubiquitous
very expensive	exorbitant, prohibitive

Instead of *a lot of / many*

a considerable number of, a substantial proportion of, numerous, a great deal of (uncountable), a wealth of, countless, the vast majority of, an abundance of

Instead of *thing*

Be specific: *factor, aspect, element, issue, feature, consideration, phenomenon, development, matter, respect.*

10.4 The mechanics of paraphrase

Five techniques. Use two or three in combination for a strong paraphrase; one alone is usually too close to the original.

1. Synonym substitution

The government should invest more in public transport. → The authorities ought to allocate greater funding to public transit.

Beware: synonyms are rarely exact. *Thin/slim/skinny/slender* differ in connotation. *Cheap/inexpensive/affordable* differ in register.

2. Word-class change (nominalisation and its reverse)

Governments decided quickly. → The speed of the government's decision... The population increased rapidly. → There was a rapid increase in the population.

This is the most powerful technique, because it forces the whole sentence to be rebuilt.

Verb	Noun	Adjective	Adverb
analyse	analysis	analytical	analytically
benefit	benefit	beneficial	beneficially
compete	competition	competitive	competitively
decide	decision	decisive	decisively
economise	economy	economic/economical	economically
educate	education	educational	educationally
environment	environment	environmental	environmentally
grow	growth	growing	—
industrialise	industry	industrial	industrially
maintain	maintenance	—	—
respond	response	responsive	responsively
signify	significance	significant	significantly
succeed	success	successful	successfully
technology	technology	technological	technologically

Word-form errors are marked at every band.* *"He was success", "an economic problem" when you meant economical, "he responded responsibly" when you meant responsively. Learn the whole family, not one member.*

3. Voice change

Researchers conducted the study. → The study was conducted by researchers.

4. Negation of the opposite

Few people supported the plan. → The plan was not widely supported. It is uncommon. → It rarely occurs. He rejected the offer. → He did not accept the offer.

5. Structural reordering

Because costs rose, demand fell. → The fall in demand was a consequence of rising costs. Although it was expensive, it worked. → Its high cost notwithstanding, it proved effective.

Paraphrase practice

Take this sentence and produce four versions:

“Original: *“Many young people today prefer to communicate online rather than face to face.”*”

- 1 *A large proportion of the younger generation now favours digital interaction over meeting in person.* (synonym + word class)
- 2 *Online communication is preferred by many of today's youth to in-person contact.* (voice)
- 3 *A significant number of young people are less inclined to interact face to face than they are to communicate through digital channels.* (negation of opposite)
- 4 *For much of the younger generation, the default mode of interaction has shifted from physical presence to online exchange.* (structural)

Do this with ten sentences a day for three weeks.

10.5 Topic vocabulary banks

Task 2 and Speaking Part 3 draw from a limited set of domains. Build twenty to thirty items for each.

Education

curriculum, syllabus, pedagogy, rote learning, critical thinking, tuition fees, scholarship, vocational training, higher education, literacy, numeracy, dropout rate, academic attainment, streaming, extracurricular, lifelong learning, distance learning, teacher-pupil ratio, standardised testing, continuous assessment

Phrases: *broaden one's horizons; instil discipline; foster independent thought; bridge the attainment gap; equip students with skills; a well-rounded education*

Environment

carbon footprint, emissions, renewable energy, fossil fuels, biodiversity, deforestation, habitat loss, conservation, sustainability, recycling, landfill, greenhouse gases, global warming, ecosystem, pollutant, single-use plastic, carbon neutral, offsetting

Phrases: *mitigate climate change; reduce our environmental impact; adopt greener practices; a finite resource; irreversible damage; at the expense of the environment*

Technology

automation, artificial intelligence, algorithm, digital divide, connectivity, data privacy, surveillance, cybercrime, innovation, obsolescence, screen time, misinformation, digital literacy, remote working, e-commerce

Phrases: *keep pace with technological change; at the click of a button; revolutionise the way we work; raise concerns about privacy; a double-edged sword (Speaking only)*

Health

obesity, sedentary lifestyle, preventive medicine, public healthcare, life expectancy, chronic illness, mental wellbeing, nutrition, epidemic, immunisation, healthcare provision, waiting times

Phrases: *lead a sedentary lifestyle; place a strain on health services; adopt a balanced diet; the stigma surrounding mental illness*

Work and economy

workforce, unemployment, job security, work-life balance, remuneration, productivity, entrepreneurship, the gig economy, redundancy, workplace culture, career progression, skills shortage, minimum wage, disposable income, cost of living, inflation, recession, GDP

Phrases: *strike a balance between work and family; climb the career ladder; a competitive job market; make ends meet; widen the wealth gap*

Society and government

legislation, policy, taxpayer, public spending, infrastructure, welfare state, social mobility, inequality, urbanisation, demographic shift, ageing population, immigration, integration, civil liberties, crime rate, rehabilitation, deterrent

Phrases: *allocate public funds; address social inequality; impose stricter regulations; the burden on the taxpayer; a deterrent effect*

Culture and media

heritage, tradition, globalisation, cultural identity, assimilation, censorship, the mass media, sensationalism, bias, freedom of expression, cultural exchange, indigenous, preservation

Phrases: *preserve cultural heritage; erode traditional values; a homogenised global culture; shape public opinion*

10.6 Formal and academic register

Task 1 and Task 2 require formal written English. Speaking allows — and at Band 7 rewards — informality and idiom.

Informal	Formal
get	obtain, acquire, receive
get worse	deteriorate, worsen
get better	improve, recover
find out	discover, ascertain, determine
put off	postpone, defer
set up	establish, found
look into	investigate, examine
bring about	cause, produce, generate
go up / go down	rise / fall, increase / decrease
deal with	address, tackle, handle
think about	consider, contemplate
a lot of	a great deal of, numerous
kids	children, young people
stuff / things	items, materials, factors
big	significant, considerable

Informal	Formal
sort of / kind of	somewhat, to some extent
show	demonstrate, illustrate, indicate
help	assist, facilitate, support
use	employ, utilise, make use of
start	commence, initiate, embark on
end	conclude, terminate, cease
need	require, necessitate
make sure	ensure, guarantee

Register rules for Writing Task 1 and 2

- ✗ No contractions: write *do not*, not *don't*.
- ✗ No phrasal verbs where a single verb exists.
- ✗ No idioms: "*at the end of the day*", "*the tip of the iceberg*", "*a piece of cake*".
- ✗ No slang, no exclamation marks, no "etc.", no "&".
- ✗ No direct address: "*As you can see...*", "*Let me tell you...*"
- ✗ No rhetorical questions as a structural device.
- ✓ Impersonal constructions: "*It could be argued that...*", "*There is evidence to suggest...*"

And the inverse, for Speaking:

Idiom is a Band 7 marker in Speaking.

It's not really my cup of tea. / I was over the moon. / It's a bit of a mixed blessing. / That's easier said than done. / I'd take it with a pinch of salt. / It's second nature to me now. / We see eye to eye on most things. / It cost an arm and a leg.

Use two or three across the test, naturally. A string of idioms crammed in sounds rehearsed and scores worse than none.

10.7 How to actually learn vocabulary

Five principles

- 1. Learn in chunks, not single words.** Store "*pose a serious threat to*", not "*pose*".
- 2. Learn the whole word family.** *analyse* / *analysis* / *analytical* / *analytically*.
- 3. Learn with a sentence you wrote yourself.** A word in your own sentence about your own life is retained; a word in a list is not.
- 4. Space the repetition.** Review at 1 day, 3 days, 1 week, 3 weeks. Use flashcards or an app that does this for you.
- 5. Force production.** Reading a word teaches recognition; writing and saying it teaches use. IELTS Writing and Speaking test production.

A realistic weekly routine: 15 new chunks per week, actively used in writing or speech within 48 hours, reviewed at spaced intervals. Sixty chunks a month, 180 over a twelve-week preparation — far more useful than 1,000 words seen once.

The word list to avoid

Lists of "Band 9 vocabulary" circulating online typically contain words like *plethora*, *myriad*, *paradigm*, *quintessential*, *ubiquitous*. These are not band-raisers. They are the words examiners see in every memorised script, usually miscollocated. Prefer accurate, well-collocated mid-frequency academic vocabulary — *substantial*, *address*, *mitigate*, *widespread*, *compelling*, *viable* — used correctly.

Chapter 11 — Pronunciation

Twenty-five per cent of the Speaking band, and the one most candidates never train

The course devotes substantial time to pronunciation, and frames it precisely: pronunciation means producing words in a way that does not create misunderstanding. As the teacher puts it, mispronunciation "may cause some kind of misunderstanding at the listener's end, which may reduce your band score."

Two things follow. First, pronunciation is trainable — it is a motor skill, not a talent. Second, the target is **intelligibility**, not an accent.

11.1 Where pronunciation problems come from

The course identifies two sources, and both are worth taking seriously.

Source 1: You learned the word wrongly.

If you first encountered a word in writing and guessed its pronunciation, or heard it mispronounced by a teacher or friend, the error fossilises. The teacher describes a friend who learned one word incorrectly years ago and has said it that way ever since.

The fix: never learn a new word without hearing it. Every dictionary app has audio. Use it every single time, including for words you are sure about.

Source 2: Interference from your first language.

Your mother tongue's sound system filters English. Sounds that don't exist in your L1 get replaced by the nearest one you have; stress patterns transfer; syllable timing transfers.

The fix: identify the specific sounds your language lacks and drill those, rather than practising "pronunciation" in general.

11.2 Minimal pairs: the sounds that carry meaning

A minimal pair is two words differing by one sound. If you cannot distinguish them, you cannot be reliably understood.

The course drills **/p/ versus /b/** at length, and the choice is instructive: these are the same in every way except **voicing** (whether the vocal cords vibrate) and **aspiration** (the puff of air).

/p/ and /b/

/p/	/b/
pay	bay
pin	bin
pear	bear
cap	cab
rope	robe
pest	best
Pepsi	—

How to feel the difference: hold a sheet of paper an inch from your mouth. Say *pin* — the paper should move sharply. Say *bin* — it should barely move. Then put a finger on your throat: /b/ vibrates, /p/ does not.

Other high-frequency minimal pairs

Contrast	Examples	Who struggles
/f/ – /v/	fan/van, safe/save, leaf/leave	German, Hindi, Arabic
/b/ – /v/	boat/vote, berry/very, ban/van	Spanish, Arabic, Korean
/p/ – /f/	pan/fan, pool/fool	Japanese, Korean
/l/ – /r/	light/right, collect/correct, glass/grass	Japanese, Korean, Chinese
/s/ – /ʃ/	sea/she, sock/shock	Greek, some Chinese
/θ/ – /s/ – /t/	think/sink, three/tree, path/pass	very widespread
/ð/ – /d/ – /z/	they/day, breathe/breed	very widespread
/n/ – /ŋ/	sin/sing, ban/bang	Spanish, Italian
/ʃ/ – /iʃ/	ship/sheep, bit/beat, live/leave	Spanish, Arabic, Japanese
/æ/ – /e/	bad/bed, man/men, sat/set	many
/ʌ/ – /uʌ/	cup/carp, but/bart	many
/ʌ/ – /uʌ/	not/note, cost/coast	many
/w/ – /v/	west/vest, wine/vine	German, Indian languages

The /θ/ and /ð/ sounds

th has two pronunciations and neither exists in most languages.

- **Voiceless /θ/** — *think, three, path, month, both, through, healthy*
- **Voiced /ð/** — *this, that, they, the, mother, breathe, either, weather*

Technique: tongue tip lightly between the teeth, blow air. For /ð/, add voice. It feels absurd; it is correct. Substituting /s/ or /t/ is the single most noticeable non-native feature in English and it does occasionally cause genuine confusion (*thin / sin, three / tree*).

11.3 Silent letters

Spelling misleads. These are the patterns worth memorising.

Silent letter	Examples
b after m	climb, comb, thumb, lamb, doubt, debt, tomb
c	muscle, scissors, science, scene
d	Wednesday, handsome, sandwich, edge
g	sign, design, foreign, champagne, gnaw
gh	thought, through, daughter, height, straight
h	hour, honest, honour, ghost, what, exhibition
k	know, knife, knee, knock
l	walk, talk, calm, half, could, salmon
n	autumn, column, hymn, condemn
p	psychology, pneumonia, receipt, cupboard

Silent letter	Examples
s	island, aisle
t	listen, castle, often (optional), Christmas, whistle
u	guess, guitar, build, biscuit
w	write, wrong, answer, sword, two

Two words the course specifically flags because candidates mispronounce them despite using them constantly: **design** (/dɪˈzaɪn/ — silent g) and **music** (/ˈmjuːzɪk/ — the u is /juː/, not /u/).

11.4 Word stress

English is a **stress-timed** language. Every multi-syllable word has one strongly stressed syllable, and getting it wrong can make the word unrecognisable even when every sound is correct.

Misplaced stress is more damaging than a wrong vowel.

PHOtograph / *phoTOgrapher* / *photoGRAPHic* — same root, three different stress patterns, and the unstressed vowels reduce to /ə/ in each. A listener hearing *photoGRAPH* instead of *PHOtograph* may not recognise the word at all.

Stress rules that actually work

Rule	Examples
Two-syllable nouns/adjectives: usually stress 1	T able, HAP py, DO ctor, MOU ntain
Two-syllable verbs: usually stress 2	be GIN , de CIDE , re LAX , for GET
Noun/verb pairs: noun stress 1, verb stress 2	RE cord (n) / re CORD (v); PRE sent / pre SENT ; IN crease / in CREASE ; CON duct / con DUCT ; EX port / ex PORT
-tion, -sion, -cian: stress the syllable before	edu C ation, deci S ion, musi C ian, informa T ion
-ity, -ify, -ical, -ular: stress the syllable before	a B ility, i D entify, e C onomical, par T icular
-ic: stress the syllable before	scien T ific, ath L etic, eco N omic
-ate (verbs): stress two back	GR aduate (v), Edu C ate, com M unicate
-ee, -eer, -ese, -ette: stress the suffix	employ EE , engin EER , Japan ESE , ciga RETT E
Compound nouns: stress the first element	BLACK board, AIR port, POST man, GREEN house
Compound adjectives: stress the second	old- FASH ioned, well- KNOWN , bad- TEM pered
Phrasal verbs: stress the particle	give UP , look AFT er, put OFF

Words IELTS candidates commonly misstress

de**VE**lop, **COM**fortable, **VE**getable, **NE**cessary, **IN**teresting, **TE**mperature, cate**G**orical, **PHO**tograph, **COL**league, **RE**staurant, de**TER**mine, **CHA**racter, **MA**nagement, a**V**ailable, de**VE**lopment, en**V**ironment, ad**VER**tisement (BrE), **PRE**ference, com**PAR**ison, ana**LY**sis, hy**PO**thesis, phe**N**omenon

11.5 Sentence stress and rhythm

Within a sentence, **content words** (nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, question words) are stressed. **Function words** (articles, prepositions, auxiliaries, pronouns, conjunctions) are unstressed and reduced.

*“I **WENT** to the **SHOP** to **BUY** some **BREAD**.”*

Four stressed syllables. Everything between them is compressed. English rhythm places stresses at roughly equal intervals regardless of how many unstressed syllables sit between them — which is why “**CATS EAT FISH**” and “the **CATS** have been **EATing** the **FISH**” take about the same time to say.

This is why English sounds “fast”.

It is not faster. It compresses unstressed syllables. If you give every syllable equal weight — natural if your first language is syllable-timed, like Spanish, French, Italian, Japanese, Turkish or Arabic — you will be understood, but you will sound effortful, and Fluency and Pronunciation both suffer.

Drill: clap a steady beat. Say a sentence with one stressed syllable per clap, cramming the unstressed syllables in between.

Weak forms

Function words have reduced pronunciations in connected speech. Learning them improves your listening as much as your speaking.

Word	Strong	Weak
and	/ænd/	/■n/, /n/ — fish ‘n’ chips
to	/tu■/	/t■/ — I want t■ go
of	/■v/	/■v/, /■/ — a cup ■ tea
for	/f■■/	/f■/
can	/kæn/	/k■n/
are	/■■/	/■/
have	/hæv/	/■v/, /v/
was	/w■z/	/w■z/
them	/ðem/	/ð■m/, /■m/
you	/ju■/	/j■/

Contrastive stress — stressing a word to change meaning:

*“I didn’t say **SHE** stole it. (someone else did) I didn’t say she **STOLE** it. (she borrowed it) I didn’t **SAY** she stole it. (I implied it)”*

Using contrastive stress deliberately is a strong Band 8 pronunciation feature.

11.6 Connected speech

Native speakers do not pronounce words in isolation. Four processes:

Process	Description	Example
Linking	Final consonant joins to initial vowel	an apple → “a-napple”; turn off → “tur-noff”

Process	Description	Example
Intrusion	/w/, /j/ or /r/ inserted between vowels	<i>go on</i> → "go- w -on"; <i>I am</i> → "I- y -am"; <i>law and order</i> (BrE) → "law- r -and"
Elision	A sound disappears	<i>next day</i> → "nex' day"; <i>friendship</i> → "frien'ship"
Assimilation	A sound changes to match its neighbour	<i>ten boys</i> → "tem boys"; <i>would you</i> → "wouldjou"

You do not have to produce these to score well, but you **must recognise them** to succeed in Listening. Practise by transcribing short stretches of natural speech (Chapter 2.11).

11.7 Intonation

The melody of speech. Wrong intonation makes correct grammar sound rude, bored or confused.

Pattern	Use	Example
Falling ■	Statements, wh-questions, commands, finished lists	<i>I live in Cairo. ■ / Where do you live? ■</i>
Rising ■	Yes/no questions, uncertainty, unfinished lists	<i>Do you like it? ■ / I bought bread ■, milk ■, and eggs ■</i>
Fall-rise ■■	Reservation, politeness, implied "but"	<i>The food was nice... ■■ (but something wasn't)</i>
Rise-fall ■■	Strong feeling, surprise	<i>That's amazing! ■■</i>

Flat intonation is the commonest pronunciation problem at Band 6.

Monotone delivery reads as disengagement even when the content is excellent. It also loses you the "range of pronunciation features" credit at Band 7 and above. Vary your pitch deliberately: go noticeably higher on the stressed syllable of the most important word in each sentence.

11.8 British and American differences

The course covers these briefly and correctly frames them as **awareness**, not a target.

Feature	British (RP)	American (GA)
/r/ after a vowel	dropped — <i>car</i> /k■/, <i>park</i> /p■k/	pronounced — /k■r/, /p■rk/
/t/ between vowels	clear /t/ — <i>water</i> /w■t■/	flapped, like /d/ — /w■d■r/
/æ/ vs /■/	<i>bath, dance, can't</i> = /■/	= /æ/
/■/	<i>hot, not</i> = /■/	= /■/
schedule	/■edju■/	/■sked■u■/
either	/■a■ð■/	/■i■ð■r/
advertisement	/■d■v■t■sm■nt/	/■ædv■r■ta■zm■nt/
Stress differences	BAL let, GA rage, ad DRESS	bal LET , ga RAGE , ad D ress

Choose one and be consistent.

Both are fully accepted. Mixing them within a sentence — American /r/ with British vowels — is the only thing that sounds odd. Pick whichever you have had more exposure to and stay with it.

Listening, however, requires both. IELTS recordings use British, American, Australian, New Zealand and Canadian speakers. Train your ear on all of them.

11.9 A pronunciation training routine

Twenty minutes a day

5 min — Minimal pairs. Pick the two contrasts your language struggles with. Say ten pairs aloud. Record yourself; play it back; can *you* hear the difference?

5 min — Shadowing. Play 20–30 seconds of a native speaker. Play it again and speak *simultaneously*, copying rhythm, stress and melody rather than just words. Then record yourself doing it alone and compare.

5 min — Word stress. Take ten new words from your vocabulary list. Look up the stress. Say each five times with exaggerated stress.

5 min — Reading aloud. Read a paragraph, marking stressed words in advance. Read it with deliberate rhythm and intonation.

Shadowing is the highest-return exercise in this chapter. It trains rhythm, intonation, connected speech, stress and fluency simultaneously, and it requires no teacher. Twenty minutes a day for six weeks produces audible change.

11.10 Pronunciation self-check

Record two minutes of yourself speaking. Then listen with these questions:

- Can I identify the stressed syllable in every multi-syllable word I used?
- Did my pitch move, or was I flat?
- Did I finish my word endings, or swallow the consonants (*-ed*, *-s*, *-t*)?
- Did I pause at clause boundaries, or in random places?
- Did I speak fast enough to sound natural and slow enough to be clear?
- Are there any words a listener would have to guess at?

The last question is the only one that really matters. **Intelligibility is the criterion.**

Chapter 12 — Study Plans and Exam-Day Management

Turning the preceding eleven chapters into a schedule you will actually follow

Knowledge of technique is worthless without practice hours. This chapter converts the book into three concrete programmes, and then deals with the last twenty-four hours.

12.1 Before you choose a plan

Answer three questions:

- 1 What is my current band?** From the diagnostic in Chapter 1.5, not from hope.
- 2 What band do I need?** The exact requirement, including any per-component minimum. A university asking for "6.5 overall with no band below 6.0" is a different target from "6.5 overall".
- 3 How many hours a week can I genuinely give?** Be honest. A plan you abandon in week two is worse than a modest plan you complete.

A realistic rate of improvement

Moving up **half a band** typically requires 80–120 hours of focused work.

Moving up **a full band** typically requires 200–300 hours.

This assumes *focused* work: timed practice with error analysis, not passive exposure. Watching English television for 200 hours will not move your band.

If your target requires more than a full band of improvement, book the test for later rather than taking it twice.

12.2 The four-week intensive

For candidates already within half a band of their target. Assumes **2–3 hours a day**.

Week 1 — Diagnose and rebuild technique

Day	Focus
1	Full diagnostic test (Chapter 1.5). Categorise every error.
2	Chapter 2 (Listening). Two practice sections, with prediction routine.
3	Chapter 3 (Reading). Skimming drill on five passages; one timed passage.
4	Chapter 4 or 5 (Task 1). Two tasks in 20 minutes each.
5	Chapter 6 (Task 2). One essay, then rewrite it with the checklist.
6	Chapter 7 (Speaking). Record Part 1 × 8 questions and one Part 2. Review.
7	Review the week's errors. Build your error log (Chapter 8.7).

Week 2 — Drill the weakest component

Spend **five of seven days** on your lowest component. Add: daily 20-minute pronunciation routine (Chapter 11.9); daily 10 vocabulary chunks (Chapter 10.7).

Week 3 — Timed practice under pressure

One full Listening and one full Reading every day, timed. One Task 1 and one Task 2 every other day. One recorded full Speaking test every other day.

Week 4 — Full mocks and consolidation

Day	Activity
22	Full mock test (L + R + W back to back, 2h40)
23	Review mock in detail
24	Weakest component only
25	Full mock test
26	Review; rewrite both essays
27	Light revision: checklists, linking words, topic vocabulary
28	Rest. No English.

12.3 The eight-week programme

For candidates a full band below target. **1.5–2 hours a day.**

Weeks	Focus	Outcome
1–2	Listening + Reading technique. Chapters 2 and 3 in full, every exercise. Untimed accuracy first.	All ten Listening question types and all nine Reading types understood and practised.
3–4	Writing. Chapters 4/5 and 6. Eight Task 1s and eight Task 2s, each written then rewritten.	The four-paragraph and PEEL structures automatic.
5–6	Speaking + pronunciation. Chapters 7 and 11. Daily recording. Thirty cue cards.	Two-minute long turn comfortable; Part 1 extension automatic.
7	Grammar and vocabulary consolidation. Chapters 9 and 10. The ten structures in 9.12 drilled to automaticity.	Error log reduced to fewer than five recurring patterns.
8	Full mocks: three complete tests, reviewed in detail.	Timing under control; no unattempted questions.

Throughout all eight weeks, daily: 20 minutes pronunciation, 15 vocabulary chunks per week, 30 minutes reading English non-fiction.

12.4 The twelve-week foundation programme

For candidates more than a full band below target, or building from a lower level.

Weeks	Focus
1–3	Language foundation. Chapter 9 (grammar) systematically: sentence types, tenses, articles, agreement. Chapter 10: 200 collocations. No timed practice yet.
4–6	Receptive skills. Chapters 2 and 3, untimed then timed. Daily dictation. Daily reading.
7–9	Productive skills. Chapters 4/5, 6, 7, 11. Twelve essays, twelve Task 1s, daily speaking recordings.
10–11	Integration. Full timed components. Weekly full mock. Detailed error analysis.
12	Taper. Two mocks early in the week, then light revision only. Rest before the test.

12.5 What effective practice looks like

Three ways candidates waste practice hours

- 1. Doing tests without reviewing them.** A test you have marked but not analysed teaches almost nothing. Budget *as much time for review as for the test itself*.
- 2. Practising untimed and hoping timing will look after itself.** It will not. Timing is a separate skill.
- 3. Writing essays no one reads, including you.** Write, then wait 24 hours, then mark your own work against the descriptors in Chapter 8, then **rewrite**. The rewrite is where improvement happens.

The review protocol

For every practice test:

- 1 Mark it. Record the raw score.
- 2 For each error, write **why** — not "careless" but the specific cause: *word limit, distractor, didn't know the synonym, ran out of time, answered from knowledge*.
- 3 Tally the causes. After five tests you will see two or three dominating.
- 4 Design a drill for the dominant cause and do it for a week.
- 5 Re-test.

12.6 The final week

Days before	Do	Don't
7–5	Two full mocks. Detailed review.	Don't learn new vocabulary.
4–3	Revise checklists, structures, linking words, topic vocabulary. One Task 2 per day.	Don't take more full mocks — the fatigue costs more than the practice gains.
2	Light revision only. Read your error log. Re-read the four component checklists.	Don't study a new question type.
1	Rest. Check documents, location, travel time. Sleep.	Don't study at all. Seriously.

Practical preparation

- **Documents:** the passport or ID you registered with. No other form is accepted. Check the name matches exactly.
- **Location and time:** know the route; plan to arrive 45 minutes early.
- **Allowed on the desk:** pencils, erasers, a transparent water bottle with the label removed.
- **Not allowed:** phones, watches (in many centres), notes, food. Lockers are provided.
- **Clothing:** layers. Test rooms are frequently too cold or too hot.

12.7 On the day

Listening (30 min + transfer)

- Use every second of the preparation pauses: word limit, keywords, word class, predicted paraphrase.
- Write answers on the question paper as you listen; transfer at the end (paper test).
- Miss one, move on within two seconds.

- Never leave a blank.

Reading (60 min)

- Twenty minutes per passage. Hard stop.
- Skim first, always.
- Transfer answers passage by passage.
- Never leave a blank.

Writing (60 min)

- **Task 2 first** if you are prone to overrunning on Task 1 — it carries twice the marks and must be protected. (If you are disciplined with time, the standard order is fine.)
- Task 1: 20 minutes, 160–190 words, overview mandatory.
- Task 2: 40 minutes — 5 plan, 30 write, 5 check.
- Check for: articles, plurals, agreement, tense, word count, paragraphing.

Speaking (11–14 min)

- Arrive with your mouth warmed up. Speak English aloud for ten minutes before you go in — to a friend, to yourself, to a wall.
- Part 1: two to three sentences, 20–40 seconds, always a reason.
- Part 2: use the full minute to write keywords; speak for the full two minutes.
- Part 3: Answer → Reason → Example → Balance. Hedge. Ask for clarification in English if you need it.
- If you make a mistake, correct it once briefly and continue. Do not dwell; do not apologise.

12.8 Managing anxiety

Three evidence-based points, all consistent with the advice the course gives its nervous students.

1. Familiarity displaces fear. The format itself should be boring by test day. If your fortieth mock Part 2 still frightens you, do ten more.

2. Physical control precedes mental control. Slow exhalation lengthens; drop the shoulders; unclench the jaw. Two minutes of slow breathing before the Speaking test measurably reduces the physiological symptoms that interfere with articulation.

3. Reframe the examiner. They are not judging you as a person. They are completing a form against published criteria. Their neutrality is professional, not personal.

And the single most useful thought to hold on the day:

You are not being asked to be a native speaker. You are being asked to demonstrate, within a known format, the specific behaviours listed in a published rubric. Every one of those behaviours is in this book, and every one of them is trainable.

Chapter 13 — Appendices

Every list in the book, gathered for final-week revision

A. The one-page summary

	Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking
Time	30 min (+10 transfer, paper)	60 min, no transfer time	60 min	11–14 min
Questions	40, four parts	40, three passages (AC) / five texts (GT)	2 tasks	3 parts
Golden rule	Read the word limit; predict; never stop listening after you write	20 min per passage; skim first; locate before deciding	Task 2 is worth double; overview is mandatory in T1	Never a short answer; always a reason
Fatal error	Exceeding the word limit	Running out of time on passage 3	No overview / no clear position	One-sentence answers, memorised speeches
Non-negotiable	No blanks	No blanks	150 / 250 word minimums	Fill the two minutes in Part 2

B. Linking words by function

Adding: furthermore, moreover, in addition, additionally, what is more, besides this, likewise, similarly
Contrasting: however, nevertheless, nonetheless, conversely, on the other hand, by contrast, that said, even so
Conceding: although, even though, while, whereas, admittedly, granted, it is true that, despite, in spite of
Causing: because, since, as, owing to, due to, on account of, given that **Resulting:** therefore, consequently, as a result, thus, hence, accordingly, for this reason **Exemplifying:** for instance, for example, to illustrate, a case in point, such as, namely, in particular **Sequencing:** to begin with, firstly, subsequently, following this, thereafter, finally **Emphasising:** indeed, notably, crucially, above all, in particular, it should be stressed that **Qualifying:** to some extent, in certain respects, arguably, broadly speaking, by and large **Concluding:** in conclusion, to conclude, in summary, on balance, all things considered, ultimately

C. Trend language (Writing Task 1)

Up: rise, increase, grow, climb, surge, soar, rocket, escalate, double, triple, quadruple **Down:** fall, decrease, decline, drop, dip, plunge, plummet, slump, tumble, halve **Stable:** remain stable/steady/constant/unchanged, level off, plateau, hold steady **Fluctuate:** fluctuate, oscillate, vary, show volatility **Peak:** peak at, reach a peak of, hit a high of, reach its highest point **Trough:** reach a trough of, bottom out at, hit a low of **Large degree:** dramatically, sharply, steeply, markedly, significantly, considerably, substantially **Small degree:** slightly, marginally, somewhat, moderately **Speed:** rapidly, swiftly, abruptly, suddenly / steadily, gradually, progressively, consistently **Approximation:** approximately, roughly, around, about, just over, just under, nearly, almost, in the region of

Prepositions: rise from X to Y; rise by Z; between 1995 and 2010; stand at 40%; a rise of 12%; over the period; during the 1990s

D. Process diagram language

Sequencers: first / initially / to begin with → next / then / subsequently / following this / once this is complete → meanwhile / simultaneously → finally / in the final stage / the cycle then repeats **Passive forms:** is collected, is then filtered, having been dried, before being packaged, must be heated **Openers:** *The diagram illustrates the process by which...* / *The process comprises [n] distinct stages, beginning with... and culminating in...*

E. Map language

Construction: was built, was constructed, was erected, a new X was added **Removal:** was demolished, was knocked down, was cleared, made way for **Conversion:** was converted into, was turned into, was redeveloped as, was replaced by **Size:** was extended, was enlarged, was reduced in size **Unchanged:** remained unchanged, was retained, was left intact **Position:** to the north/south/east/west of, in the north-east corner, along the western edge, adjacent to, opposite, surrounding, on the opposite bank, in the centre

F. Letter phrases (General Training Task 1)

Formal openings: I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with... / to request... / to enquire about... / to apply for... / with regard to... **Informal openings:** I thought I'd drop you a line to... / It's been ages! / I'm writing to invite you to... **Complaining:** I was extremely disappointed to find that... / fell considerably short of / caused me considerable inconvenience **Requesting:** I would be grateful if you could... / I would appreciate it if... / I must insist that... **Apologising:** Please accept my sincere apologies for... / I am afraid I will be unable to... **Formal closings:** I look forward to receiving your response at your earliest convenience. / Thank you for your attention to this matter. **Informal closings:** Do write back soon. / Can't wait to hear from you! / Give my love to everyone. **Sign-offs:** Dear Sir or Madam → **Yours faithfully** | Dear Mr/Ms Name → **Yours sincerely** | Dear [first name] → **Best wishes** / **All the best** / **Love**

G. Essay frames (Writing Task 2)

Introduction: [Paraphrase of prompt]. [Thesis: position + two reasons]. **Body topic sentences:** *The most compelling argument for X concerns...* / *A second and equally significant consideration is...* / *Those who oppose this view point to...* **Developing:** *This is because...* / *The mechanism is straightforward...* / *The result is that...* / *A case in point is...* / *It might be objected that... However,...* **Conclusion:** *In conclusion, while [concession], [restated position], principally because [reason 1] and [reason 2].*

The five question types: Opinion (agree/disagree) | Discussion (both views + opinion) | Problem/Cause and Solution | Advantages/Disadvantages (+ do they outweigh?) | Two-part question

H. Speaking functional language

Fillers: Well... / Let me think... / That's an interesting question... / To be honest... / Actually... / I suppose... **Extending:** ...mainly because... / ...for instance... / ...though I used to... / ...unlike most of my friends... / ...at least when... **Opinion (Part 3):** I'd argue that... / It seems to me that... / My own view is that... / I'm inclined to think... **Speculating:** It may well be that... / I suspect... / It's conceivable that... / Presumably... **Hedging:** To some extent... / Up to a point... / More often than not... / It rather depends on... **Conceding:** I take the point that... / There's certainly something in that, although... / Admittedly... **Clarifying:** Sorry, could you rephrase that? / Do you mean X specifically, or Y more generally? **Part 3 shape:** Answer → Reason → Example → Balance

I. Cue card frameworks

Card type	Frame
A person	Who they are and how you know them → what they're like (two qualities, with examples) → a specific incident → why they matter to you
A place	Where and when → what it looks/feels like → what you did there → why it stays with you
An object	What it is and where it came from → description → how you use it → why it's significant
An event	Background → what happened, in sequence → how you felt at the time → how you see it now
An activity	What it is and how you started → how often and with whom → a memorable occasion → what you get from it
An experience	Context → what happened → the difficulty or turning point → what you learned

J. The twenty-five common errors

discuss about → discuss | in nowadays → nowadays | according to me → in my view | the peoples are → people are | informations → information | more better → better | I am agree → I agree | suggested me to go → suggested that I go | interesting in → interested in | despite of → despite | although...but → although | since 5 years → for 5 years | have seen him yesterday → saw him yesterday | the 90's → the 1990s | one of the reason → one of the reasons | every students → every student | make a research → conduct research | most of people → most people | in the other hand → on the other hand | depend of → depend on | is consist of → consists of | married with → married to | explain me → explain to me | the both → both | comprised of → comprises

K. Uncountable nouns

information, advice, research, knowledge, equipment, furniture, luggage, traffic, money, news, progress, evidence, work, accommodation, transport, staff, weather, homework, software, feedback, damage, behaviour, pollution, machinery, scenery

fewer + countable | less + uncountable | many + countable | much + uncountable

L. The ten range-building structures

- 1 Not only does X..., but it also...
- 2 What matters most is not X but Y. (cleft)
- 3 Policies introduced in 2010... (reduced relative)
- 4 Having reviewed the evidence, they... (perfect participle)
- 5 Were governments to invest more,... (inverted conditional)
- 6 The more accessible X becomes, the greater...
- 7 While the costs are considerable,...
- 8 Greater emphasis should be placed on... (passive + modal)
- 9 The rapid expansion of X has placed pressure on... (noun-phrase subject)
- 10 Unless action is taken, the trend is likely to continue.

M. Concession structures

Expression	Followed by
although / even though / while / whereas	a clause
despite / in spite of	a noun or -ing form
despite the fact that	a clause
however / nevertheless / nonetheless	a new sentence (or ;)
but / yet	a clause, after a comma

Never: *although ... but | despite he studied | He studied hard, however, he failed.*

N. Vocabulary upgrades

good → sound, constructive, favourable, effective, compelling, outstanding **bad** → detrimental, adverse, misguided, dire, disruptive, severe **very big** → enormous, vast, substantial | **very small** → negligible, marginal **very important** → crucial, vital, paramount | **very difficult** → demanding, arduous **a lot of** → a considerable number of, a substantial proportion of, numerous **thing** → factor, aspect, element, issue, feature, consideration **show** → demonstrate, illustrate, indicate | **deal with** → address, tackle **get worse** → deteriorate | **get better** → improve | **find out** → ascertain

O. Word-stress quick reference

-tion, -sion, -cian, -ity, -ical, -ular, -ic: stress the syllable **before** the suffix *-ee, -eer, -ese, -ette*: stress the **suffix**
 Two-syllable **nouns/adjectives**: stress 1 | Two-syllable **verbs**: stress 2 **Noun/verb pairs**: **RE**cord (n) / **re**CORD (v); **IN**crease / **in**CREASE; **PRE**sent / **pre**SENT **Compound nouns**: stress the first element (**AIR**port) | **Compound adjectives**: stress the second (old-**FASH**ioned)

P. Spoken numbers

double four = 44 | treble/triple eight = 888 | oh = 0 | nineteen ninety-four = 1994 | two thousand and nine = 2009 | a quarter past eight = 8.15 | twenty to seven = 6.40 | half past nine = 9.30 | half nine (BrE) = 9.30 | thirty pounds fifty = £30.50 | one point five million = 1,500,000

Q. Final checklists

Listening

Word limit noted • keywords underlined • word class predicted • moved on after a miss • kept listening past the first plausible answer • plurals checked • spellings checked • digits used • no blanks

Reading

Skimmed first • paragraph topics noted • keywords underlined • located before deciding • T/F/NG answered only from the text • quantifiers circled • 20-minute limit respected • transferred per passage • no blanks

Writing Task 1

Four paragraphs • prompt paraphrased • overview present, no figures • figures in the body • three comparisons • no opinion • no bullet points • 160–190 words • *by* vs *to* correct

Writing Task 2

Every part of the task answered • four/five paragraphs • thesis stated • topic sentence per paragraph • ideas developed with mechanism + example • position consistent • no new ideas in conclusion • varied linkers • mixed sentence types • 260–300 words

Speaking

No answer under two sentences • no Part 1 answer over 40 seconds • full two minutes in Part 2 • all four cue-card prompts covered • complex sentences in Part 3 • hedging used • English fillers only • clarification asked in English • word endings audible

R. A closing note

This book was assembled from twelve hours of recorded live teaching — a real classroom, with real students making real mistakes and being corrected in real time. That origin shows in its priorities. It spends more time on word limits than on rare vocabulary; more on the overview paragraph than on stylistic flourish; more on not giving short answers than on sounding native.

That is the right emphasis. The candidates who improve fastest are almost never the ones who learn the most English between attempts. They are the ones who stop throwing marks away: who count the words, who write the overview, who keep listening after the first plausible answer, who give a reason with every answer, who finish passage three.

None of that requires talent. All of it requires practice, honestly timed and honestly reviewed.

Good luck.